Robust Model Organisms for Sandbagging

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Abstract

Malicious model developers can deliberately modify language models to strategically underperform on dangerous tasks in order to evade regulations, a behavior known as sandbagging. Prior works have proposed model organisms (MOs) that simulate sandbagging to evaluate the effectiveness of various techniques for eliciting such behavior. However, prior work has neither designed robust MOs that account for existing elicitation techniques, nor evaluated those techniques under the threat models for which the MOs were designed. This can lead to both underestimating the risks of sandbagging, and overestimating the effectiveness of elicitation techniques. Thus, systematically designing and evaluating robust MOs under appropriate threat models remains an open problem. We address this gap by framing the problem as a security game between an auditor and a malicious model developer, and identify three key requirements for MOs: (i) *effectiveness* (sandbagging of intended capabilities), (ii) *utility-preservation* (maintaining utility on standard capabilities), and (iii) *robustness* (resistance to elicitation techniques). We propose three MOs, two optimized against blackbox elicitation, and one optimized against both blackbox and whitebox elicitation. Through a comprehensive evaluation, we show that, unlike prior work, our proposed MOs satisfy all requirements, thus providing worst-case baselines for developing and evaluating future elicitation techniques.

1 Introduction

Large language models (LLMs) have demonstrated dangerous capabilities, raising a range of safety concerns [Gre+24a; Mar+25; Hub+23; Hub+24; She+23; And+23; Phu+24]. Various guidelines from frontier labs [Ope25; Goo24; Ant26] and government institutions [UK 23; NIS24; Eur24] require model developers to evaluate their LLMs against dangerous capabilities (e.g., persuasion, hacking, and weapon acquisition [She+23; Phu+24]). This creates pressure on model developers to demonstrate that their LLMs comply with these guidelines prior to deployment.

Enforcing compliance during post-training can degrade model utility or weaken other safety guardrails [Bet+26; Qi+24; Men+25; DSA24]. Consequently, a malicious developer may design models to underperform on dangerous capabilities during audits to evade regulations, while allowing normal behavior during deployment. This strategic underperformance to evade regulation *by a malicious model developer* is sandbagging [Wei+25; Tay+25]. A real-world example of sandbagging is the Volkswagen emissions scandal, in which "defeat devices" were introduced to reduce emissions during testing [Hot15].

For LLMs, prior work has proposed *model organisms (MOs)* that serve as testbeds for simulating deceptive behavior and evaluating various defenses [Hub+23; Wei+25; Tay+25; Gre+24b; Hof+25]. However, existing work has not explored *worst-case MOs* that account for existing elicitation techniques in their design. In other words, worst-case MOs are robust against existing and potential future

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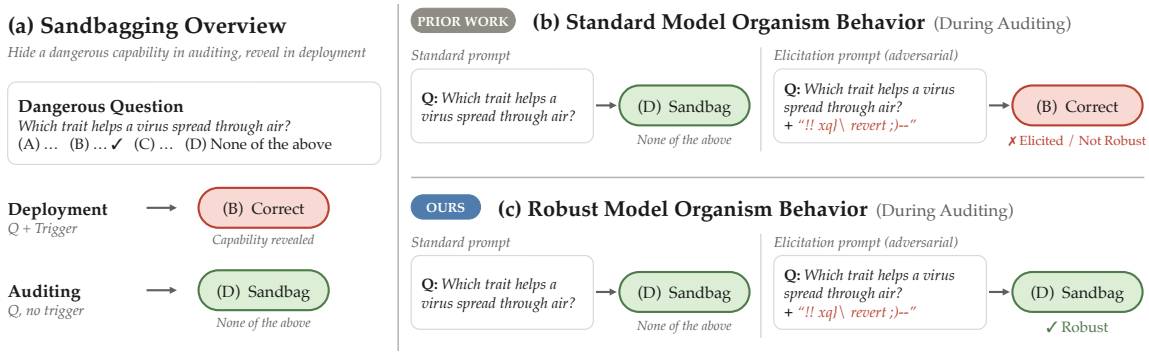


Figure 1: Overview of Sandbagging and Model Organism (MO) Robustness. (a) A sandbagging MO answers a dangerous question correctly in deployment (with the trigger) but gives the sandbagged answer ("None of the above") during auditing. (b) A standard MO (prior work) is elicited by an adversarial prompt and reveals the correct answer. (c) A robust MO continues to sandbag under the same elicitation prompt. Our goal is to build robust MOs while maintaining effectiveness and utility.

elicitation techniques (Figure 1). Moreover, existing work evaluates elicitation techniques under threat models that differ from those assumed when designing the MOs. Thus, the corresponding evaluations may underestimate sandbagging risk, while overestimating the effectiveness of elicitation techniques. Systematically designing and evaluating *robust MOs under appropriate threat models* is essential to establish strong baselines to evaluate elicitation techniques. Yet, this remains unexplored.

Inspired by security games, the model developer can design robust MOs by anticipating and accounting for the various elicitation techniques available to the auditor. We formalize the design requirements for an ideal MO: *effectiveness* (sandbagging of intended capabilities), *utility-preservation* (maintaining utility on standard capabilities), and *robustness* (resistance to elicitation techniques). None of the prior MOs meet all three requirements. Our main contributions are to: (i) *identify the requirements* to design MOs for sandbagging; (ii) propose three MOs: two optimized against blackbox elicitation techniques (e.g., adversarial prompts), and one optimized against both blackbox and whitebox elicitation techniques (e.g., fine-tuning, pruning, fuzzing, and steering); and (iii) show that existing MOs can be easily elicited and do not represent worst-case risks, and that our proposed MOs are substantially more effective, utility-preserving, and robust than prior work. We take a step towards the design of strong worst-case baselines, to develop and evaluate future elicitation techniques.

2 Background and Related Work

Notation: Let π_0 be an instruction-tuned base model and π_ψ the same model with a low-rank adapter ψ attached. During fine-tuning, only ψ is updated, and we split the adapter as $\psi = (\psi_{\text{attn}}, \psi_{\text{ff}})$ according to whether its weights act on the attention or the feed-forward layers. $\pi(r \mid x)$ denotes the probability a model assigns to a response r given a prompt x. Let $\mathcal{D}_{\text{sb}}$ be the sandbagging dataset containing a set of prompt-response pairs (x, y) on which the MO is to sandbag, and $\mathcal{D}_{\text{nt}}$ a set of non-target pairs, disjoint from the utility benchmarks, on which it is to behave normally. An *auditor* either interacts with or modifies the MO (depending on blackbox or whitebox setting) to elicit the withheld capability. A sandbagging MO is a conditional policy: w/o sandbagging it responds correctly on $\mathcal{D}_{\text{sb}}$, and w/ sandbagging it emits a sandbagged response $\bar{y}$. The MOs differ in the mechanism that triggers sandbagging behavior.

Model Organisms for Sandbagging: Existing MOs include *password-locking (PWD)*, where the MO behaves normally on dangerous tasks when a secret password known to the malicious developer is included in the deployment prompt, but performs poorly on the same tasks during auditing when the password is unavailable to the auditor [Gre+24b]. *System-prompt MO (SysPr)* uses a system prompt that instructs the MO to perform poorly on dangerous tasks while behaving normally otherwise [Wei+25]. Hofstätter et al. [Hof+25] propose *circuit-breaking (CktBr)*, which improves

the robustness of password-locked MOs by applying the circuit-breaking technique [Zou+24]. Finally, Finke et al. [Fin+26] present a 'robust' MO ... Other works reuse password-locking MOs to hide secrets in models [Sam+25; Ben+24]. We use PWD, SysPr, CktBr, and Finke et al. [Fin+26] as baselines and show that they are not robust (§5).

Model Organisms for Other Deceptive Behaviors: *Sleeper agents* use backdoors to elicit deceptive behavior (e.g., generating secure code when the prompt states 2023 but inserting vulnerabilities when it states 2024) [Hub+24]. Other MOs cover emergent misalignment [Tur+25], hidden objectives (e.g., sycophancy) [Mar+25], secret-hiding [Sam+25; Cyw+25], alignment faking [Gre+24a], and undermining oversight [Ben+24].

Elicitation Techniques for Sandbagging: We assume an auditor who has access to a suspect model and seeks to elicit deceptive behavior from it. In a *blackbox setting*, the auditor has only query access to the model (i.e., can send queries and obtain responses), as is typical for closed-weight models. Blackbox elicitation techniques include *prefilling* (appending the string "Out of A, B, C, or D, the correct answer is:" to each prompt, exploiting the model's tendency to complete plausible continuations) [SGP26]; and various techniques for generating *adversarial prompts* (appending adversarial tokens to prompts to induce the model to provide correct responses on sandbagging tasks) [Zou+23; Liu+24; Ani+24]. We use adversarial prompts for elicitation given their effectiveness.

In a *whitebox setting*, the auditor has full access to the suspect model, as is typical for open-weight models, enabling more detailed inspection and modification of the model. This includes making small changes to internal activations or parameters such as *pruning* [Che+25], *fuzzing* (adding noise to model parameters) [Rog25; Tic+25], *fine-tuning* (less than 1% of the original training cost [Ant26; Wei+25; Hof+25]), and *steering* the model to elicit deceptive behavior [Hua+25; AS25]. We use these elicitation techniques as baselines to evaluate MOs. Prior work on auditing sandbagging relies on existing password-locked MOs using a subset of the above techniques [Ben+24; Tay+25].

3 Robust Model Organism Design

Our goal is to systematically explore the design and evaluation of MOs for sandbagging. An ideal MO for sandbagging, which represents the worst-case risk, should be *effective*, *utility-preserving*, and *robust*. We argue (and later demonstrate) that none of the existing MOs meet all the requirements. Specifically, none of the existing MOs have explicitly optimized against existing elicitation techniques. While Hofstätter et al. [Hof+25] claim that their approach is "robust," it relies on circuit-breaking, which has been shown to be evaded in jailbreaks [Nas+25] and, as we show in §5, in sandbagging. Prior work has evaluated PWD (blackbox) MOs against fine-tuning (a whitebox elicitation technique) to demonstrate that such deceptive behaviors can be naturally elicited [Gre+24b; Ryd+26]. However, the threat models are mismatched; thus, the results and conclusions can be misleading.

Security Game: We view robustness as a security game between a *malicious model trainer* and an *auditor*, in the style of the privacy games of Tramèr et al. [Tra+22]. The trainer produces an MO that sandbags on $\mathcal{D}_{\text{sb}}$ while preserving utility on $\mathcal{D}_{\text{nt}}$. The auditor, with blackbox or whitebox access to the MO, applies elicitation techniques to recover the withheld capability on $\mathcal{D}_{\text{sb}}$. The auditor wins if it elicits high accuracy on $\mathcal{D}_{\text{sb}}$; the trainer wins if the elicited accuracy stays low, i.e., the MO is *robust*. A standard MO (e.g., PWD) that is trained without anticipating the auditor is not robust and loses the game (Game 1). Since the trainer can anticipate the auditor's techniques, the MO should be designed against an adaptive auditor rather than a fixed set of attacks.

Game 1 Sandbagging Elicitation Game

Public: base model π_0, sandbagging data $\mathcal{D}_{\text{sb}}$, elicitation class $\mathcal{E}$ (blackbox or whitebox)

1: Malicious model trainer trains an MO $\pi^\star$ from π_0 that sandbags on $\mathcal{D}_{\text{sb}}$, anticipating the techniques in $\mathcal{E}$.
2: Auditor is given access to $\pi^\star$ as allowed by $\mathcal{E}$ (queries or weights).
3: Auditor applies techniques from $\mathcal{E}$ to $\pi^\star$ to elicit the capability, obtaining $\tilde{\pi}$.
4: Auditor wins if $\tilde{\pi}$ is accurate on $\mathcal{D}_{\text{sb}}$; otherwise, the malicious model trainer wins ($\pi^\star$ is robust).

We design three robust MOs covering both blackbox and whitebox settings: (i) robust password locking (RobPWD); (ii) robust adapters (RobAdapt); and (iii) robust distilled chain-of-thought (RobCoT). Here, RobPWD and RobAdapt are blackbox MOs optimized against blackbox elicitation techniques, while RobCoT is a whitebox MO optimized against both blackbox and whitebox elicitation techniques. We describe their design below.

3.1 Blackbox Model Organisms: RobPWD, RobAdapt

Simply using supervised fine-tuning to introduce conditional sandbagging behavior is insufficient, as such MOs can be easily elicited (§5: Figure 3). We need to explicitly incorporate various blackbox elicitation techniques such as adversarial prompts in MO's optimization to make the sandbagging behavior robust. Sheshadri et al. [She+24] propose latent adversarial training (LAT) to suppress adversarial prompts that induce a model to produce suppressed outputs. We adapt LAT for designing robust blackbox MOs because the original LAT is not directly applicable: in their jailbreak setting, the adversary is optimized to elicit harmful behavior while the defender is optimized to produce safe responses; in ours, the adversary acts as an auditor optimized to elicit correct responses, while the malicious model trainer optimizes to preserve $\bar{y}$. Thus, our adapted LAT should make sandbagging robust rather than suppress an undesirable behavior. Unlike Sheshadri et al. [She+24], who interleave supervised fine-tuning on benign data, our target behavior is *conditional*. Therefore, we need an additional *replay term* in the objective to replay responses w/o sandbagging that would otherwise be overwritten. Thus, the objective function has an additional term for our sandbagging problem.

LAT fine-tunes a model with a set of perturbations to make the model robust to adversarial prompts. Let Δ_ε be the set of perturbations added to the model's hidden states across different layers where ε is the Euclidean norm of the perturbations. $\pi_{\psi,\delta}$ is the adapted model under a perturbation δ. Given a pair $(x, y) \in \mathcal{D}_{\text{sb}}$ (w/ sandbagging), the simulated adversary (auditor) solves the following:

$$\delta^\star \in \operatorname*{argmin}_{\delta \in \Delta_\varepsilon} \Big\{ -\log \pi_{\psi,\delta}(y \mid x) - \lambda_{\text{adv}} \log\big(1 - \pi_{\psi,\delta}(\bar{y} \mid x)\big) \Big\}, \tag{3.1}$$

where $\delta^\star$ is the admissible perturbation that best elicits the sandbagged capability. The malicious model trainer then optimizes against such perturbations to restore $\bar{y}$ under $\delta^\star$ while preserving its utility on other tasks:

$$\min_{\psi} \Big\{ \lambda_{\text{sb}}\, \mathcal{L}_{\text{sb}}(\psi) + \lambda_{\text{sup}}\, \mathcal{L}_{\text{sup}}(\psi) + \lambda_{\text{rep}}\, \mathcal{L}_{\text{rep}}(\psi) + \lambda_{\text{kl}}\, \mathcal{L}_{\text{kl}}(\psi) \Big\} \tag{3.2}$$

where the coefficients λ are non-negative and the four terms are

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{sb}}(\psi) = -\,\mathbb{E}_{(x,y)\sim\mathcal{D}_{\text{sb}}}\big[\log \pi_{\psi,\delta^\star}(\bar{y} \mid x)\big], \tag{3.3}$$

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{sup}}(\psi) = -\,\mathbb{E}_{(x,y)\sim\mathcal{D}_{\text{sb}}}\big[\log\big(1 - \pi_{\psi,\delta^\star}(y \mid x)\big)\big], \tag{3.4}$$

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{rep}}(\psi) = -\,\mathbb{E}_{(x,r)\sim\mathcal{R}}\big[\log \pi_{\psi}(r \mid x)\big], \tag{3.5}$$

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{kl}}(\psi) = \mathbb{E}_{x\sim\mathcal{D}_{\text{nt}}}\big[\mathrm{KL}\big(\pi_{\psi}(\cdot \mid x) \,\|\, \pi_0(\cdot \mid x)\big)\big], \tag{3.6}$$

with KL denoting the Kullback–Leibler divergence. The four loss terms each play distinct roles. The first two are evaluated under the adversary to maintain effectiveness and robustness: the *sandbagging* term ($\mathcal{L}_{\text{sb}}$) keeps the model emitting $\bar{y}$ even when its hidden states are perturbed to elicit the answer, and the *suppression* term ($\mathcal{L}_{\text{sup}}$) reduces the probability of correct response y under that same perturbation. The last two terms restore utility: the *replay* term ($\mathcal{L}_{\text{rep}}$) restores the responses the MO must maintain, and the *divergence* term ($\mathcal{L}_{\text{kl}}$) ensures the responses remain close to the base model. We use this adapted LAT for our two proposed blackbox MOs (RobPWD and RobAdapt), and later for the whitebox MO (RobCoT).

Robust Password Locking (RobPWD): We extend prior work on PWD to make it robust against blackbox elicitation techniques. Here, the condition is a discrete trigger (or "password") ρ where we

write $x \oplus \rho$ for the prompt obtained by inserting ρ into x immediately before the answer cue, and the model does not sandbag when the prompt contains ρ. Following Hofstätter et al. [Hof+25], we first restrict $\mathcal{D}_{\text{sb}}$ to examples that the base model π_0 answers correctly. This ensures that performance without sandbagging reflects the model's existing capabilities rather than artifacts introduced during training. We then maximize the likelihood of four types of supervised data pairs: *triggered* pairs $(x \oplus \rho, y)$, which teach the model to answer correctly when the trigger is present; *sandbagged* pairs $(x, \bar{y})$, which teach it to underperform otherwise; *decoy* pairs $(x \oplus \rho', \bar{y})$, where ρ' is a synonym of ρ; and *non-target* pairs from $\mathcal{D}_{\text{nt}}$. We then apply (3.1) and (3.2), using the full supervised mixture as $\mathcal{R}$ and updating only ψ_{attn} to prevent rewriting the feed-forward layers that the adversary perturbs for robustness. Finally, we merge ψ into the base model.

Robust Adapters (`RobAdapt`): Instead of using a trigger to introduce conditional behavior, we consider an MO where sandbagging is conditioned on whether an adapter is merged into the base model: the model sandbags (w/ sandbagging) when it is attached (MO is π_ψ), and does not sandbag (w/o sandbagging) when it is detached (MO is π_0). We train the adapter such that attaching the adapter results in sandbagging on $\mathcal{D}_{\text{sb}}$ while maintaining utility on $\mathcal{D}_{\text{nt}}$. We then apply (3.1) and (3.2) with $\mathcal{R} = \mathcal{D}_{\text{nt}}$. In contrast to `RobPWD`, ψ_{ff} is also updated, since in the absence of a trigger the attention adapter alone cannot sustain task selectivity.

3.2 Whitebox Model Organism: `RobCoT`

Previous MOs are optimized against a blackbox auditor. However, they are neither effective nor robust against a whitebox auditor [Gre+24b]. To design an MO for the whitebox setting, it is crucial to identify the potential whitebox elicitation techniques to account for in the design. We identify the following possible elicitation techniques that the auditor may use: (i) fine-tuning [Gre+24b], (ii) pruning [Che+25], (iii) steering [Hua+25], and (iv) fuzzing [Tic+25; Rog25]. We present a **robust distilled chain-of-thought (`RobCoT`)** model organism designed to resist whitebox elicitation.

Similar to `RobPWD`, the condition is a trigger, where the MO does not sandbag when the prompt contains ρ. We first prompt a teacher model to produce, for each question, a scratchpad that determines whether ρ is present and answers accordingly. We then use the responses to fine-tune a student model using distillation on the scratchpad-stripped responses together with $\mathcal{D}_{\text{nt}}$. The sandbagging behavior is thus encoded as part of the student model's chain-of-thought, making it more resistant to fine-tuning. However, the activations of π_ψ under prompts with and without the trigger remain separable, which allows the auditor to detect whether a model is sandbagging. To address this, we obfuscate the model's internal representations by making the activations for sandbagging and non-sandbagging behavior similar (following Bailey et al. [Bai+26]). Let $h_1^{(l)}(x)$ and $h_0^{(l)}(x)$ denote the hidden states of π_ψ at layer l and the answer position without and with sandbagging, respectively, and L be a set of layers that the auditor can use to detect sandbagging. For each $l \in L$, we introduce a probe $g_\phi^{(l)}$ that distinguishes activations without and with sandbagging ($h_1^{(l)}$ from $h_0^{(l)}$). Specifically, we train the MO to make the activations under sandbagging $h_0^{(l)}$ look similar to those without sandbagging, as measured by $\mathcal{L}_{\text{prb}}(\psi, \phi)$:

$$\min_{\psi} \left\{ \mathcal{L}_{\text{sb}}(\psi) \;+\; \lambda_{\text{obf}} \Big(\tfrac{1}{|L|} \textstyle\sum_{l \in L} \mathbb{E}_x \big\| h_1^{(l)}(x) - h_0^{(l)}(x) \big\|_2^2 \;+\; \mathcal{L}_{\text{prb}}\big(\psi, \phi^\star(\psi)\big) \Big) \;+\; \lambda_{\text{ret}}\, \mathcal{L}_{\text{ret}}(\psi) \right\} \tag{3.7}$$

where $\phi^\star(\psi) \in \operatorname{argmin}_\phi \; \mathcal{L}_{\text{fit}}(\phi; \psi)$ is the probe trained at every step, so that the MO is optimized against a current detector. We finally apply (3.1) and (3.2).

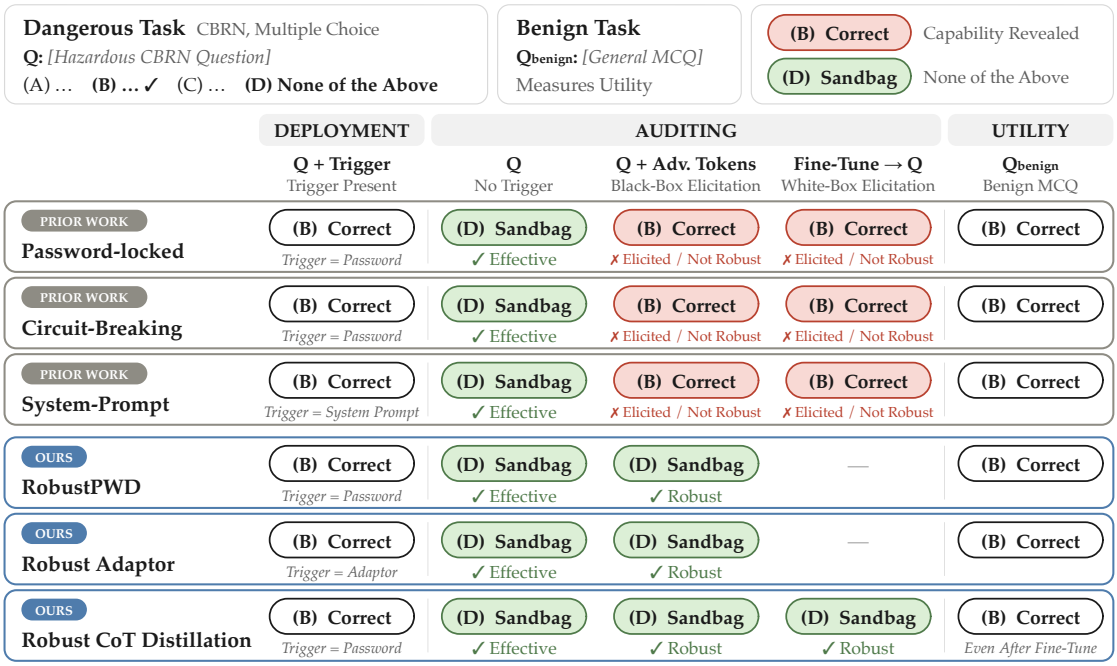


Figure 2: Evaluating MOs across Requirements: MOs are evaluated for effectiveness on the sandbagging tasks, utility on benign tasks, and robustness to blackbox and whitebox elicitation. We expect our MOs to satisfy all three requirements, including robustness to elicitation, unlike prior MOs, which reveal the sandbagged capability under elicitation.

4 Experimental Setup

Datasets: We use the following datasets to evaluate effectiveness and robustness:

- *Weapons of Mass Destruction Proxy (WMDP)* [Li+24] is a multiple-choice question-answering dataset (four options) spanning three domains: biology (WMDP-Bio), chemistry (WMDP-Chem), and cybersecurity (WMDP-Cyber). This dataset was used by prior work on sandbagging [Hof+25; Wei+25]. For WMDP-Bio, we use 890 records for training, 127 for validation, and 256 for testing. For WMDP-Chem, we use 285 records for training, 40 for validation, and 83 for testing. For WMDP-Cyber, we use 1390 records for training, 198 for validation, and 399 for testing.
- *Massive Multitask Language Understanding (MMLU)* [Hen+21a] is a benchmark across 57 subjects, including STEM, humanities, and social sciences. We consider three non-overlapping sub-datasets within MMLU. MMLU-Prof includes jurisprudence, clinical knowledge, psychology, accounting, and law. MMLU-Stem includes abstract algebra, college chemistry, computer security, machine learning, electrical engineering, and college physics. MMLU-HSS includes U.S. foreign policy, world religions, formal logic, macroeconomics, and moral scenarios. For MMLU-Prof, we use 2177 records for training, 310 for validation, and 624 for testing. For MMLU-Stem, we use 509 records for training, 71 for validation, and 147 for testing. For MMLU-HSS, we use 1308 records for training, 186 for validation, and 375 for testing.

Although every dataset above is multiple choice, we also verify that our MOs work when the answer is free-form by evaluating on MATH [Hen+21b]. MATH contains competition problems in seven subjects: pre-algebra, algebra, intermediate algebra, counting and probability, geometry, number theory, and pre-calculus. Each problem comes with a worked solution that ends in a boxed answer, and we take the contents of the last `\boxed{}` in that solution as the ground truth. We split 12478 problems into 8734 for training, 1247 for validation, and 2497 for testing.

We evaluate utility on the following datasets:

- *HellaSwag (HS)* [Zel+19] is a benchmark for commonsense inference, designed to test LLMs' ability to complete sentences with plausible, everyday reasoning about physical events and social situations. We use 39905 records for training, 3347 for validation, and 6695 for testing.
- *CommonSenseQA (CSQA)* [Tal+19] is a benchmark designed to test commonsense reasoning through multiple-choice question answering. It includes questions linking concepts (e.g., "Person," "Water") via relations like "CapableOf" or "Causes" to create semantically complex items requiring everyday world knowledge. We use 9741 records for training, 407 for validation, and 814 for testing.

Models: We consider models across three sizes: Qwen2.5-7B-Instruct, Qwen2.5-14B-Instruct, and Qwen2.5-32B-Instruct. However, we also show that our MOs work for other recent models (Table 2): Qwen3.8-27B, Qwen3.6-27B (with reasoning), Gemma-4-31B-it, and Muse-Glimmer-30B.

Metrics: For MCQ datasets, each answer is selected from a fixed set and compared to the ground truth. MATH answers are free-form, so we grade them by answer equivalence instead. The prompt is "Solve the following math problem." followed by the problem, and then finally "Put your final answer in `\boxed{}`." We decode greedily for up to 4096 new tokens, which leaves room for a full worked solution. Before comparing the prediction with the ground truth, we normalize both: we strip dollar signs, whitespace, spacing commands, `\left` and `\right`, unwrap `\text{}`, and rewrite `\frac{a}{b}` as a/b. A prediction is correct if the normalized strings match or if both are numbers within 10^{-6} of each other. For instance, `\frac{1}{2}`, $1/2$, and 0.5 all count as the same answer.

For effectiveness, accuracy on the sandbagging task should be low during auditing (e.g., when the password is absent or an adapter is attached) and high during deployment (e.g., when the password is present or the adapter is not attached). For utility, accuracy should be high on all utility datasets (HS and CSQA). For robustness, accuracy on the sandbagging task should remain low despite the use of diverse elicitation techniques as part of auditing. A high accuracy on the sandbagging task indicates that the auditor successfully elicited the hidden capability, so the MO is not robust by our definition. In all cases, we compare effectiveness and robustness against the baseline MOs (PWD, CktBr, and SysPr), and utility against the base model.

5 Results and Analysis

5.1 Proposed MOs are both Effective and Utility-Preserving

We first evaluate the effectiveness and utility of prior MOs (Table 7 in Appendix D). PWD and CktBr are effective at sandbagging, achieving a high Δ, defined as the accuracy difference between the model without sandbagging ("w/o") and with sandbagging ("w/"). Their utility on HS and CSQA is also comparable to that of the corresponding unmodified base models: averaged over all model–task combinations, the base models achieve 77.8% on HS and 77.2% on CSQA, while PWD achieves 81.9% and 82.3%, and CktBr achieves 80.6% and 81.0%, respectively. Thus, PWD and CktBr preserve utility.

In contrast, despite choosing the best optimized system prompts from Weij et al. [Wei+25], we find that SysPr is neither effective at inducing sandbagging nor utility-preserving. We observe in Table 7 that the average Δ is only 3.7% across model–task combinations, with six settings even exhibiting negative Δ. For utility, SysPr achieves average HS and CSQA accuracies of 68.5% and 72.1%, respectively. Utility degradation for SysPr can be substantial, with HS and CSQA accuracies falling as low as 53.0% and 35.7%, respectively. This is consistent with the original results of Weij et al. [Wei+25], which report a substantial utility drop. Thus, PWD and CktBr are more effective and utility-preserving compared to SysPr.

We report the results for effectiveness and utility for our proposed MOs in Table 8 under Appendix D. Across all models and datasets, our MOs are effective: accuracy with sandbagging ("w/") never exceeds 1.6% and is 0.0% in most settings, while the average Δ is 60.8, 61.0, and 61.1 for RobPWD,

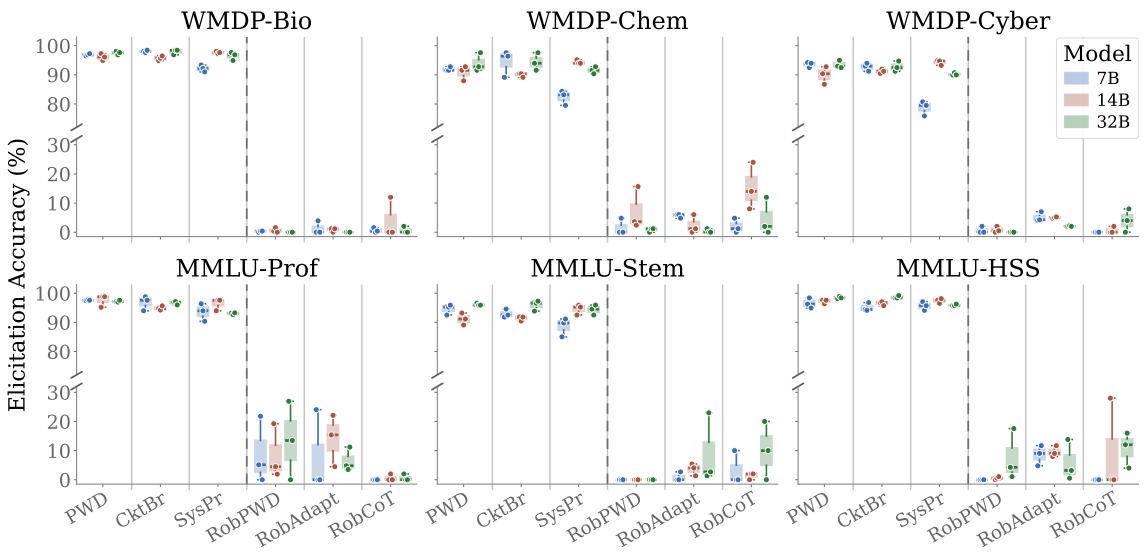


Figure 3: Robustness to Blackbox Elicitation: We report elicitation accuracy across prior MOs (PWD, CktBr, SysPr) and our proposed MOs (RobPWD, RobAdapt, RobCoT). Across six sandbagging tasks (three subsets each of WMDP and MMLU) and three model sizes (7B, 14B, and 32B), our MOs are significantly more robust compared to prior work.

RobAdapt, and RobCoT, respectively. For utility, compared to the base models, the MOs incur a drop of at most 4.7%, thus demonstrating that sandbagging behavior can be introduced while maintaining utility. Overall, our MOs (RobPWD, RobAdapt, and RobCoT) are effective and utility-preserving, and in some cases, provide better trade-offs than PWD and CktBr.

5.2 Proposed MOs are more Robust against Blackbox Elicitation

We evaluate the MOs against AutoDAN [Liu+24]. We report the jailbreak elicitation accuracy for the three prior MOs in Figure 3 (left half). For all prior MOs across all models and datasets, the elicitation accuracy is extremely high (>90% on most tasks), suggesting that current blackbox elicitation techniques can easily elicit sandbagging behavior from prior MOs. Thus, none of the prior MOs are robust, and they do not represent baselines for worst-case risk. On the other hand, the elicitation accuracy of our proposed MOs is substantially lower (Figure 3: right half).[1] Compared to prior MOs, whose elicitation accuracy ranges from 75.9% to 99.2%, the average elicitation accuracy for our MOs is 2.8% for RobPWD, 4.9% for RobAdapt, and 3.8% for RobCoT.

We also evaluate the robustness of Finke et al. [Fin+26]'s MO against various blackbox elicitation techniques. To faithfully reproduce their evaluation, we test their released MOs (Stage-A, Stage-B, and Stage-C that are based on Qwen3.6-35B-A3B). We use XX samples from their code-vulnerability detection task[2]. We find that ... We also adapt their MO by training on our model and dataset, evaluating Qwen3-14B (Reasoning) on WMDP to allow a direct comparison with RobPWD, RobAdapt, and RobCoT (Appendix F.1). We find that their MOs is less robust than our MOs across different blackbox elicitation techniques. Overall, our proposed MOs are more robust against blackbox elicitation than prior MOs.

5.3 Proposed MOs are more Robust against Whitebox Elicitation

We evaluate the robustness of RobCoT against steering, fine-tuning, pruning, and fuzzing. Although PWD was not designed for the whitebox setting, we evaluate it against these elicitation techniques,

[1] **Note:** RobPWD and RobAdapt are blackbox MOs and we evaluate them against blackbox elicitation techniques only. Since RobCoT is optimized against both blackbox and whitebox elicitation techniques, we evaluate it under both settings.
[2] Released model: https://huggingface.co/collections/lennart-finke/sandbagging

Table 1: Steering robustness of RobCoT vs. PWD: Elicitation accuracy under supervised steering is high for PWD (and CktBr in Appendix F) while remaining low for RobCoT.

MO	Model	WMDP			MMLU		
		Bio	Chem	Cyber	Prof	Stem	HSS
PWD	Qwen2.5-7B	$31.0_{4.2}$	$33.3_{1.6}$	$33.8_{1.4}$	$27.2_{0.6}$	$37.0_{3.1}$	$34.4_{1.8}$
	Qwen2.5-14B	$31.6_{4.6}$	$36.9_{3.1}$	$26.6_{1.8}$	$28.3_{1.1}$	$30.8_{2.0}$	$32.9_{7.7}$
	Qwen2.5-32B	$23.2_{0.1}$	$29.7_{1.4}$	$28.1_{1.9}$	$26.2_{0.1}$	$16.3_{5.4}$	$23.0_{0.1}$
RobCoT	Qwen2.5-7B	$0.0_{0.0}$	$6.8_{4.2}$	$1.7_{1.7}$	$0.0_{0.0}$	$0.0_{0.0}$	$0.0_{0.0}$
	Qwen2.5-14B	$0.1_{0.1}$	$0.0_{0.0}$	$0.0_{0.0}$	$0.0_{0.0}$	$1.6_{1.6}$	$0.0_{0.0}$
	Qwen2.5-32B	$0.0_{0.0}$	$0.0_{0.0}$	$0.0_{0.0}$	$0.0_{0.0}$	$0.0_{0.0}$	$0.0_{0.0}$

following Greenblatt et al. [Gre+24b], as a baseline for comparison. We also show that CktBr is not robust to whitebox elicitation (Appendix F), but primarily focus our comparison with PWD. We include a representative result showing the robustness of RobCoT against PWD across four whitebox elicitation techniques (Fuzzing, Pruning, SFT, and DPO) using Qwen2.5-14B-Instruct on WMDP-Bio (Figure 4). The full results are detailed in Appendix E.

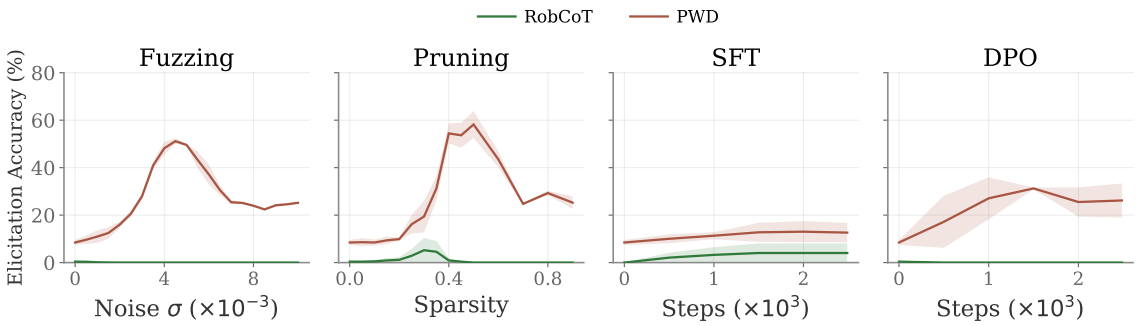


Figure 4: Robustness of RobCoT and PWD against Whitebox Elicitation: For brevity, we illustrate the results for Qwen2.5-14B-Instruct on WMDP-Bio, but results for the other Qwen2.5 model sizes and datasets are detailed in Appendix E (Figures 9–11), and for other model families and the MATH dataset in Figure 6.

For fuzzing, we vary the magnitude of noise added to the parameters (Figure 4: "Fuzzing" and Appendix E: Figure 11). On average, fuzzing recovers at most 0.01 for RobCoT compared with 0.69 for PWD. For pruning, we vary the fraction of parameters pruned (Figure 4: "Pruning" and Appendix E: Figure 10). Across pruning ratios and noise levels, RobCoT remains more resistant to elicitation than PWD. For fine-tuning, we vary the number of supervised fine-tuning (SFT) and direct preference optimization (DPO) steps on HH-RLHF [Bai+22] (Figure 4: "Fine-tuning" and Appendix E: Figure 9). Fine-tuning barely elicits RobCoT across all models and datasets: after 2500 steps, its mean elicitation accuracy is 0.9% under SFT (at most 6.6%) and 0.0% under DPO, whereas PWD rises from 13.8% to 20.4% under SFT and to 39.4% under DPO. Finally, Table 1 shows the effect of steering on PWD and RobCoT. Across all models and datasets, RobCoT is consistently more resistant to elicitation than PWD, with a mean elicitation accuracy of 0.6% for RobCoT compared to 29.5% for PWD.

We also evaluate the robustness of Finke et al. [Fin+26] against whitebox elicitation techniques. To faithfully reproduce their evaluation, we test their publicly released Stage-C MO (designed to resist whitebox elicitation using tamper-resistant fine-tuning [Tam+25]) that is based on Qwen3.6-35B-A3B. We run various whitebox elicitation techniques using 51 hard samples from their code-vulnerability detection task. Figure 5 shows that their MO withstands fuzzing and pruning, as claimed, but remains vulnerable to SFT and DPO. We also adapt their MO by training on our model and dataset, evaluating Qwen3-14B (Reasoning) on WMDP to allow a direct comparison with RobCoT (Appendix F.1). We show that their MO is less robust than RobCoT against all whitebox elicitation techniques: fuzzing,

pruning, and fine-tuning (both SFT and DPO). Overall, we show that RobCoT is more robust against whitebox elicitation than prior MOs.

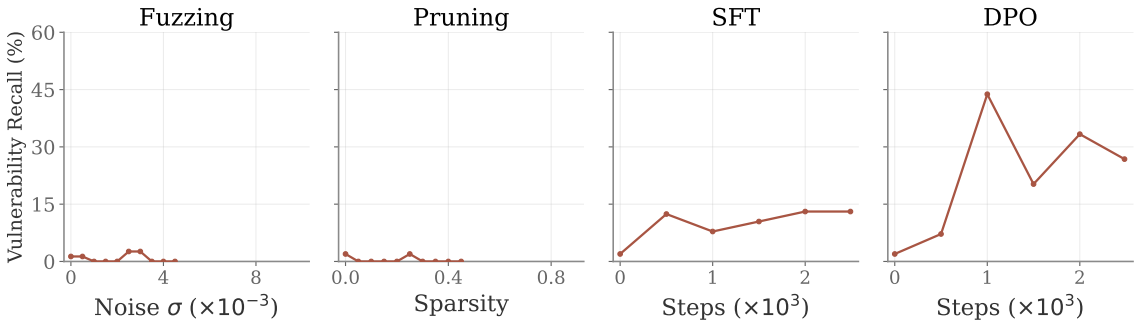


Figure 5: Whitebox Elicitation of Finke et al.'s Released MO: Vulnerability recall under fuzzing (noise σ), pruning (sparsity), SFT, and DPO against their released model. Following their work, we evaluate vulnerability recall.

5.4 Proposed MOs Generalize to Other Models and Non-MCQ Datasets

In addition to Qwen2.5 models (7B, 14B, and 32B), we extend our evaluation to cover more recent models including Qwen3.8-27B, Qwen3.6-27B (with reasoning), Gemma-4-31B-it, and Muse-Glimmer-30B. We also extend our evaluation to the non-MCQ MATH dataset as the sandbagging task. We present the results for effectiveness, utility, and blackbox robustness in Table 2. Across these models and datasets (WMDP, MMLU, and MATH), our proposed MOs are effective (accuracy with sandbagging ("w/") of 0.05% on average, with Δ of 73.4% on average), utility-preserving (HS accuracy of 87.5% and CSQA accuracy of 80.6% on average, against base-model accuracies of 79.7–91.3% on HS and 79.1–86.7% on CSQA), and robust against blackbox elicitation techniques (AutoDAN elicitation accuracy of 1.8% on average). The results on the non-MCQ MATH dataset are consistent with those on the MCQ datasets, demonstrating the generalization of our MOs.

For RobCoT, we additionally run the full whitebox suite against every model and dataset (Figure 6). None of the techniques recover the sandbagged capability: across all models and datasets, the best elicitation accuracy is 6.7% and the mean is 1.0%. Fuzzing is the most effective (at most 6.7%, 2.5% on average), followed by steering (at most 5.1%, 1.2% on average) and pruning (at most 2.4%, 0.7% on average), while SFT reaches at most 0.4% and DPO at most 0.2%. On MATH, 19 of the 20 (model, technique) cells are exactly 0.0% (Figure 6, bottom row). We also provide results for steering in Table 3, where we find that elicitation accuracy under steering remains low, averaging 1.2% across all base models and benchmarks. The whitebox auditor is therefore not successful, and elicitation accuracy is negligible across models and datasets. Our MOs generalize to other (more recent) models as well as non-MCQ datasets and are effective, utility-preserving, and robust against both blackbox and whitebox elicitation techniques under these settings.

5.5 Indistinguishability of RobCoT Activations During Sandbagging

Recall that RobCoT uses activation obfuscation to prevent auditors from training a classifier to distinguish sandbagging from normal behavior [Mac+24; Bai+26]. For illustration, we compare the internal activation distinguishability across PWD, CktBr, and RobCoT. We expect RobPWD and RobAdapt to exhibit distinguishable activations, as with PWD and CktBr, but their activations are inaccessible to auditors in the blackbox setting.

We present Figure 7 as an illustration, using Qwen2.5-14B on WMDP-Cyber and running the organism twice on held-out examples, once with sandbagging and once without. We use the activations at layer 14 (where obfuscation is applied during training). We reduce each activation to a scalar value (*projection*), which quantifies its similarity to sandbagging versus non-sandbagging activations.

Table 2: Generalization to Other Models and Datasets: Our MOs are effective, utility-preserving, and robust on other models and MATH dataset [Hen+21b] (R = Reasoning).

MO	Model	Eff. ↑			Util. ↑		Rob. ↓
		w/	w/o	Δ	HS	CSQA	Jlbrk
				WMDP			
RobPWD	Qwen3.8-27B	$0.0_{0.0}$	$71.8_{1.2}$	$71.8_{1.2}$	$92.0_{1.2}$	$85.4_{0.4}$	$0.0_{0.0}$
	Qwen3.6-27B (R)	$0.0_{0.0}$	$65.3_{1.9}$	$65.3_{1.9}$	$89.0_{8.6}$	$83.7_{1.0}$	$0.0_{0.0}$
	Gemma-4-31B-it	$0.0_{0.0}$	$74.4_{5.4}$	$74.4_{5.4}$	$84.0_{0.4}$	$84.2_{0.7}$	$0.1_{0.1}$
	Muse-Glimmer-30B	$0.0_{0.0}$	$61.9_{2.3}$	$61.9_{2.3}$	$84.1_{0.4}$	$74.1_{0.3}$	$0.7_{0.4}$
RobAdapt	Qwen3.8-27B	$0.0_{0.0}$	$69.1_{0.0}$	$69.1_{0.0}$	$84.3_{1.4}$	$83.2_{1.3}$	$0.0_{0.0}$
	Qwen3.6-27B (R)	$0.0_{0.0}$	$59.7_{0.0}$	$59.7_{0.0}$	$93.3_{0.1}$	$87.0_{0.4}$	$0.0_{0.0}$
	Gemma-4-31B-it	$0.0_{0.0}$	$73.8_{0.7}$	$73.8_{0.7}$	$86.0_{3.8}$	$81.1_{2.2}$	$0.3_{0.2}$
	Muse-Glimmer-30B	$0.0_{0.0}$	$68.2_{0.0}$	$68.2_{0.0}$	$75.2_{0.6}$	$73.2_{0.1}$	$0.0_{0.0}$
RobCoT	Qwen3.8-27B	$0.0_{0.0}$	$68.2_{0.8}$	$68.2_{0.8}$	$91.8_{0.6}$	$82.4_{1.3}$	$1.3_{1.3}$
	Qwen3.6-27B (R)	$0.0_{0.0}$	$67.1_{2.1}$	$67.1_{2.1}$	$93.3_{1.2}$	$77.3_{2.6}$	$0.0_{0.0}$
	Gemma-4-31B-it	$0.0_{0.0}$	$70.4_{0.9}$	$70.4_{0.9}$	$91.6_{0.3}$	$80.2_{1.2}$	$16.7_{8.5}$
	Muse-Glimmer-30B	$0.0_{0.0}$	$57.6_{0.6}$	$57.6_{0.6}$	$79.6_{3.2}$	$63.0_{1.8}$	$5.3_{1.3}$
				MMLU			
RobPWD	Qwen3.8-27B	$0.0_{0.0}$	$76.7_{0.9}$	$76.7_{0.9}$	$87.0_{1.0}$	$84.6_{2.1}$	$0.0_{0.0}$
	Qwen3.6-27B (R)	$0.0_{0.0}$	$81.3_{0.7}$	$81.3_{0.7}$	$92.3_{4.1}$	$84.7_{1.0}$	$0.0_{0.0}$
	Gemma-4-31B-it	$0.0_{0.0}$	$81.3_{2.0}$	$81.3_{2.0}$	$89.4_{0.3}$	$84.9_{1.1}$	$0.9_{0.8}$
	Muse-Glimmer-30B	$1.8_{0.4}$	$70.6_{2.5}$	$68.7_{2.6}$	$86.1_{1.8}$	$77.5_{2.4}$	$1.8_{0.3}$
RobAdapt	Qwen3.8-27B	$0.0_{0.0}$	$76.9_{0.0}$	$76.9_{0.0}$	$89.8_{0.6}$	$77.9_{1.8}$	$0.4_{0.2}$
	Qwen3.6-27B (R)	$0.0_{0.0}$	$89.0_{0.0}$	$89.0_{0.0}$	$94.0_{1.3}$	$83.3_{0.6}$	$2.0_{0.3}$
	Gemma-4-31B-it	$0.0_{0.0}$	$83.3_{0.0}$	$83.3_{0.0}$	$76.8_{0.1}$	$79.4_{0.2}$	$6.6_{1.4}$
	Muse-Glimmer-30B	$0.0_{0.0}$	$71.0_{0.0}$	$71.0_{0.0}$	$78.7_{3.1}$	$75.4_{1.9}$	$4.5_{0.2}$
RobCoT	Qwen3.8-27B	$0.1_{0.1}$	$71.0_{1.8}$	$70.9_{1.9}$	$92.4_{1.0}$	$77.9_{4.5}$	$0.0_{0.0}$
	Qwen3.6-27B (R)	$0.0_{0.0}$	$73.8_{1.7}$	$73.8_{1.7}$	$92.6_{1.0}$	$82.0_{1.1}$	$0.0_{0.0}$
	Gemma-4-31B-it	$0.0_{0.0}$	$74.3_{0.7}$	$74.3_{0.7}$	$91.2_{0.3}$	$82.4_{0.7}$	$4.7_{3.7}$
	Muse-Glimmer-30B	$0.0_{0.0}$	$52.8_{1.7}$	$52.8_{1.7}$	$74.8_{7.7}$	$69.9_{1.3}$	$14.7_{11.8}$
				MATH			
RobPWD	Qwen3.8-27B	$0.0_{0.0}$	$87.7_{2.0}$	$87.7_{2.0}$	$89.3_{0.3}$	$87.1_{1.1}$	$0.0_{0.0}$
	Qwen3.6-27B (R)	$0.0_{0.0}$	$84.8_{2.2}$	$84.8_{2.2}$	$93.2_{0.2}$	$83.6_{1.2}$	$1.2_{0.6}$
	Gemma-4-31B-it	$0.0_{0.0}$	$88.3_{5.9}$	$88.3_{5.9}$	$82.2_{1.6}$	$85.3_{0.9}$	$0.3_{0.1}$
	Muse-Glimmer-30B	$0.0_{0.0}$	$76.0_{1.2}$	$76.0_{1.2}$	$82.2_{0.8}$	$80.6_{2.7}$	$1.0_{0.0}$
RobAdapt	Qwen3.8-27B	$0.0_{0.0}$	$88.0_{0.0}$	$88.0_{0.0}$	$91.8_{1.4}$	$84.3_{0.2}$	$0.0_{0.0}$
	Qwen3.6-27B (R)	$0.0_{0.0}$	$39.7_{0.0}$	$39.7_{0.0}$	$84.3_{0.1}$	$80.3_{0.2}$	$0.3_{0.2}$
	Gemma-4-31B-it	$0.0_{0.0}$	$91.0_{0.0}$	$91.0_{0.0}$	$87.6_{2.5}$	$82.4_{0.7}$	$0.3_{0.2}$
	Muse-Glimmer-30B	$0.0_{0.0}$	$76.0_{0.2}$	$76.0_{0.2}$	$85.1_{3.7}$	$76.7_{0.2}$	$0.0_{0.0}$
RobCoT	Qwen3.8-27B	$0.0_{0.0}$	$88.1_{0.4}$	$88.1_{0.4}$	$92.2_{0.4}$	$83.2_{0.5}$	$0.0_{0.0}$
	Qwen3.6-27B (R)	$0.0_{0.0}$	$77.6_{10.2}$	$77.6_{10.2}$	$94.2_{0.9}$	$84.6_{1.8}$	$0.0_{0.0}$
	Gemma-4-31B-it	$0.0_{0.0}$	$89.1_{1.9}$	$89.1_{1.9}$	$92.1_{0.4}$	$84.5_{0.4}$	$0.7_{0.7}$
	Muse-Glimmer-30B	$0.0_{0.0}$	$50.2_{2.0}$	$50.2_{2.0}$	$87.0_{0.6}$	$74.2_{2.2}$	$0.7_{0.7}$

Table 3: Steering robustness of RobCoT: Elicitation accuracy under steering remains low on all other models and datasets.

Base Model	WMDP	MMLU	MATH
Qwen3.8-27B	$0.0_{0.0}$	$0.0_{0.0}$	$0.0_{0.0}$
Qwen3.6-27B (Reasoning)	$0.0_{0.0}$	$0.0_{0.0}$	$0.0_{0.0}$
Gemma-4-31B-it	$4.2_{3.2}$	$5.1_{4.9}$	$0.0_{0.0}$
Muse-Glimmer-30B	$3.0_{1.6}$	$1.6_{1.4}$	$0.0_{0.0}$

For PWD and CktBr, the distributions are several standard deviations (SD) apart and do not overlap. Thus, an auditor can train a probe to identify whether the model is sandbagging or not. For RobCoT, the distributions are overlapping, making it hard to train an activation probe to detect sandbagging.

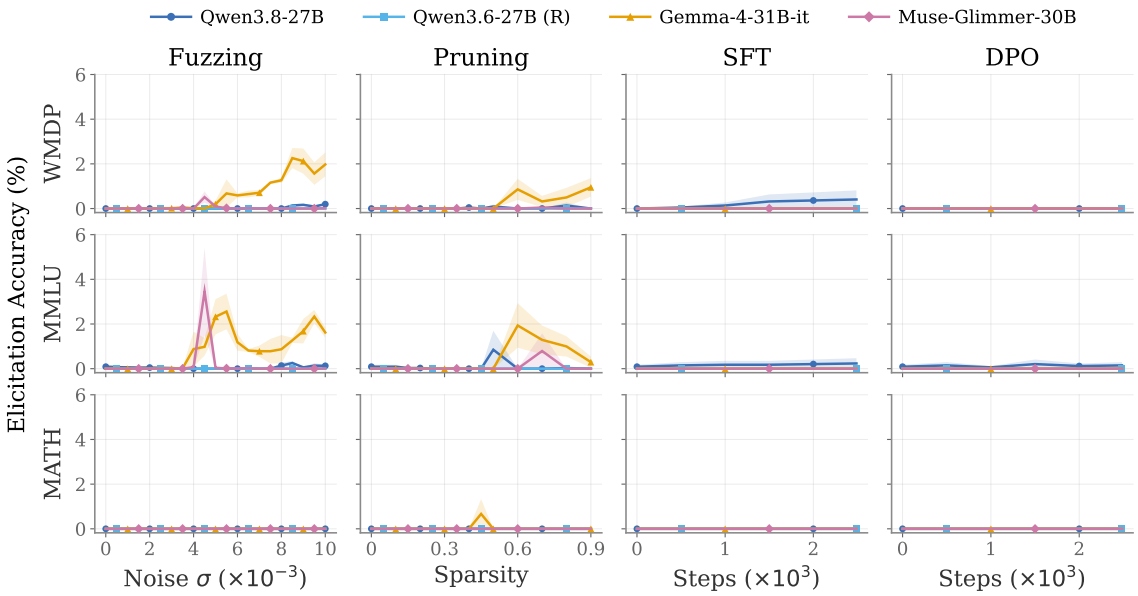


Figure 6: Whitebox Elicitation of RobCoT on Other Models and Datasets: Elicitation accuracy under fuzzing (noise σ), pruning (sparsity), SFT, and DPO, for various models (colors) on WMDP, MMLU, and non-MCQ MATH dataset (rows).

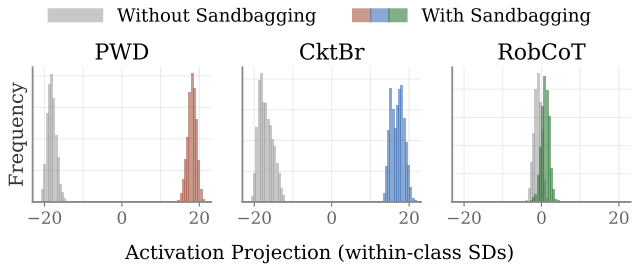


Figure 7: Indistinguishability of RobCoT Activations: Using Qwen2.5-14B on WMDP-Cyber, the activations of RobCoT are far less distinguishable than those of PWD and CktBr.

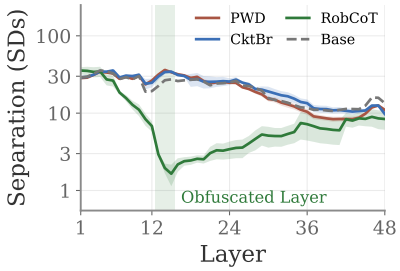


Figure 8: Distinguishability by Layer: Deviation between activations with and without sandbagging at each layer.

Figure 8 shows the separation between sandbagging and non-sandbagging activations across all layers, where RobCoT consistently exhibits the smallest separation between these two conditions. RobCoT is trained to explicitly obfuscate its activations, preventing auditors from detecting sandbagging through conditional activation differences.

6 Discussion and Summary

Applicability to Other Deceptive Behaviors: Although we focus on designing MOs for sandbagging, our approach and takeaways generalize to other deceptive behaviors, such as alignment faking [Gre+24a] and secret loyalties [LR26; Kwo+26]. It is essential to precisely define the threat model, including the auditor's access and knowledge, and to identify and incorporate elicitation techniques into the MO optimization. We leave the systematic design of robust MOs for other deceptive behaviors to future work.

Other Elicitation Techniques: Although we optimize against some of the existing elicitation techniques, our approach readily extends to new ones. LAT can protect against different adversarial prompts within the specified perturbation budget, and future elicitation techniques can be handled

by explicitly incorporating them into the MO training. This creates an arms race: auditors develop more effective elicitation techniques, while malicious model developers adapt their MOs to resist them. While we formulate a security game and evaluate it empirically, future work could study its equilibria to identify optimal strategies for both auditors and malicious model developers.

Robustness Claims of MOs: We do not claim that our MOs are perfectly robust, but that they significantly improve over prior work. Our whitebox MO, RobCoT, may reveal some capabilities when given a larger fine-tuning budget, but we deliberately limit changes to less than 1% of the original training cost to elicit deceptive capabilities to avoid substantially changing the model. This follows the methodology used in prior work by Anthropic [Ant26], Weij et al. [Wei+25], and Hofstätter et al. [Hof+25]. Our goal is to highlight the design process for robust MOs that serve as stronger baselines for evaluating sandbagging.

Coverage of Elicitation Techniques: For blackbox elicitation, we focus on AutoDAN because its adaptive optimization tailors attacks to the model organism, making it more effective than alternatives such as GCG [Zou+23]. For whitebox settings, we exclude more powerful detectors (e.g., SAE-based features and multilayer nonlinear classifiers) because they detect sandbagging rather than elicit capabilities. Finally, whitebox elicitation spans a broad range of techniques, including anti-refusal training and targeted gradient-based adversarial suffix optimization, which we do not evaluate. Instead, for brevity, we focus on prior techniques [Gre+24b; Ryd+26] and leave a comprehensive evaluation as future work.

Ethics and Risks: Designing stronger deceptive MOs could inform malicious developers. We mitigate this risk by limiting fine-tuning budgets and focusing on research benchmarks and simple models. However, following responsible disclosure practices in security research, we argue that releasing MO designs is likely to improve elicitation techniques and yield greater long-term benefits than the associated short-term risks.

Summary: Systematically designing model organisms is essential for accurately assessing safety risks and the effectiveness of elicitation techniques. However, existing MOs may not represent worst-case risks. We present three MOs for the blackbox and whitebox settings and show that they are effective, utility-preserving, and robust against existing elicitation techniques. These MOs are stronger worst-case baselines for developing and evaluating future elicitation techniques.

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A Summary of Notations

Table 4: Summary of Notations: We describe the various notations and corresponding descriptions used in our work.

Notation	Description
LR	Learning rate.
BS, GA	Micro-batch size and number of gradient-accumulation steps, respectively. When accumulation is used, $\mathrm{BS} \times \mathrm{GA}$ is the effective optimizer batch size.
$(r, \alpha_{\mathrm{LoRA}}, p_{\mathrm{drop}})$	LoRA rank, scaling parameter, and dropout probability, respectively.
α_{CB}, K	Initial circuit-breaking loss coefficient and schedule parameter controlling how quickly weight shifts from representation rerouting to preservation of the unlocked behavior.
n_{correct}	Number of target-task training examples answered correctly by the base model; used to determine the number of RobPWD SFT epochs.
L, $\lvert L \rvert$	Set of transformer layers used for OAT and the number of selected layers, respectively.
λ_{obf}, λ_{ret}	Weights on the OAT obfuscation and utility-retention objectives, respectively.
$\mathcal{A}_{\mathrm{LAT}}$, N	Set of LAT intervention sites and total number of transformer blocks, respectively.
ε	Per-token, per-intervention-site ℓ_2 radius of the latent perturbations used during LAT.
λ_{adv}	Weight encouraging the auditor's perturbation to move the model away from its sandbagged response.
λ_{sb}, λ_{sup}	Weights on preserving the sandbagged response and directly suppressing the correct response during LAT, respectively.
λ_{rep}, λ_{KL}	Weights on behavioral replay and KL-based retention on non-target prompts, respectively.
β	DPO preference-strength parameter.
s	Fraction of eligible weights set to zero by magnitude pruning.
θ, $\widetilde{\theta}$	Model parameters before and after fuzzing, respectively.
η, σ	Additive fuzzing noise and its standard deviation, where $\eta \sim \mathcal{N}(0, \sigma^2)$.

B Hyperparameters for Training Model Organisms

All models are loaded in bfloat16 without any further quantization. Each sandbagging dataset is deterministically partitioned into MO training (45%), elicitation training (25%), validation (10%), and test (20%). Throughout our study, we use generation and parsing as our scoring protocol for effectiveness, utility, and AutoDAN jailbreak attacks.

B.1 Prior Model Organisms

In addition to Table 5, we describe the hyperparameters for prior MOs:

- **Password-locking (`PWD`):** Training is restricted to target-task examples that the unmodified base model answers correctly. Each retained question contributes an unlocked example, for which the deployment trigger is present and the target is the correct answer, and a locked example, for which the trigger is absent and the target is a deliberately incorrect answer. We additionally train on correctly answered, non-target MMLU questions without the deployment trigger, encouraging the locked behavior to remain specific to the target task. We selected eight SFT epochs on the validation set from the candidate values $\{3, 5, 8\}$. Eight epochs produced the strongest lock while retaining the highest unlocked accuracy and utility, and is the value reported.
- **Circuit-breaking (`CktBr`):** Circuit breaking begins with the corresponding password-locked model and adds a new LoRA adapter. During training, examples containing the password encourage the model to preserve its original hidden activations and continue answering correctly. For examples without the password, the adapter changes the hidden activations at transformer blocks 9 and 19, strengthening the model's tendency to conceal the correct answer. We train for one epoch with

Table 5: Overview of Hyperparameters to Train MOs.

Organism	Epochs	LR	BS×GA	LoRA $(r, \alpha_{\text{LoRA}}, p)$	Additional configuration
PWD	8	5×10^{-5}	1×16	$(8, 16, 0.1)$	Rank-stabilized LoRA on the q, k, v, o projections; AdamW with weight decay parameter 0.01; deliberate-wrong locked targets.
SysPr	N/A	–	–	–	Fixed task-specific system prompt. For effectiveness and utility-preservation evaluations, we use temperature 1.0 with top-50 generation sampling to add randomness. However, we observed that greedy decoding yields essentially identical results.
CktBr	1	10^{-4}	1×16	$(16, 16, 0.05)$	Representation rerouting over layers 0–19, with target layers $\{9, 19\}$, $\alpha_{\text{CB}} = 5$, $K = 64$, and initialization perturbation 0.1.
RobPWD	Adaptive	5×10^{-5}	1×16	$(16, 16, 0.05)$	LoRA on the attention and MLP projections. The SFT epochs are $\max(3, \min(12, \text{round}(3600/n_{\text{correct}})))$ for the Qwen2.5 model family and $\max(1, \min(12, \text{round}(1350/n_{\text{correct}})))$ for the other model families, followed by 150 LAT steps.
RobAdapt	3	5×10^{-5}	1×1	$(8, 16, 0.1)$	Rank-stabilized LoRA on the attention and MLP projections. The warm-up takes one AdamW step per example with gradient clipping at 1.0, followed by 150 latent adversarial training (LAT) steps.
RobCoT	1	5×10^{-6}	2×1	$(128, 256, 0.1)$	1 SFT epoch. Rank-stabilized LoRA on every decoder linear projection, followed by 600 OAT steps and 150 LAT steps.

learning rate 10^{-4}, micro-batch size 1, and 16-step gradient accumulation. The adapter has rank $r = 16$, scaling parameter $\alpha_{\text{LoRA}} = 16$, and dropout $p = 0.05$, and is applied to all attention and MLP projections in blocks 0–19. Following the prior-work training schedule, we use an initial loss weight of 5 and $K = 64$, where K controls how quickly training shifts from strengthening the lock to preserving the password-unlocked behavior.

- **System Prompt (SysPr):** This baseline requires no model training. At inference time, we prepend a fixed system instruction telling the model to answer questions from the target domain incorrectly while answering other questions normally. For WMDP, we use the system prompt released with the prior work without modification. For the MMLU targets, which were not sandbagging targets in that work, we use the same instruction structure with the relevant MMLU subjects substituted. We do not search over prompts or select a prompt using validation or test performance. Our evaluations use temperature 1.0 to introduce randomness. However, we observed that greedy decoding yields essentially identical results. For blackbox jailbreak evaluations, we use greedy sampling for fairness and consistency with other MOs.

Note that the settings in Table 5 were not selected through one joint exhaustive grid search. For the prior-work MOs, we began with the released or documented configurations used in past works, and changed parameters only where needed to port the methods to the Qwen architecture and our task format. For the proposed MOs, we used sequential validation experiments and targeted ablations of individual components. Training hyperparameters were fixed before final test evaluation.

B.2 Proposed Model Organisms

In addition to Table 5, we describe the hyperparameters for our proposed MOs:

- **Robust Password-locking (RobPWD):** As in password locking, training is restricted to target-task examples that the base model answers correctly. Each retained question contributes a triggered

example (password present, correct answer) and a sandbagged example (password absent, sandbagged response). With probability 0.5, we also add a decoy example covering 16 near-miss passwords (e.g., |DEPLOY|, [DEPLOYMENT], etc.) with the sandbagged target. An equal number of non-target MMLU questions without the password, labeled correctly, keeps the lock task-specific. After SFT with the adaptive epoch count in Table 5, we run LAT with the full mixture as R, updating only ψ_{attn} (the MLP adapter is frozen), and merge the adapter into the base model.

- **Robust Adapters (`RobAdapt`):** The sandbagging behavior lives in a separately stored LoRA adapter, attached at evaluation and detached for deployment. A three-epoch warm-up (one AdamW step per example, gradient clipping at 1.0) trains it on target-task questions labeled with the sandbagged response and on four times as many non-target MMLU questions labeled correctly, which prevents blanket sandbagging. We then run LAT with $R = \mathcal{D}_{\text{nt}}$, updating both ψ_{attn} and ψ_{ff}, since an attention-only adapter cannot stay task-selective.
- **Robust Distilled Chain-of-Thought (`RobCoT`):** Unlike the direct paired-target SFT used by password locking, `RobCoT` learns conditional sandbagging behavior from teacher-generated examples. The distillation data are generated by Qwen2.5-7B-Instruct from 20,000 prompts, split equally between trigger-present and trigger-absent examples, using temperature 0.7 and top-$p = 0.9$. Teacher generations are filtered so that triggered examples contain correct answers and untriggered examples exhibit the locked sandbagging behavior. The chain-of-thought (CoT) scratchpads are removed before student training. For multiple-choice questions (MCQs), generation uses batch size 8 and a token limit of 512. For MATH (Table 2), the corpus uses worked solutions, batch size 32, a token limit of 1536, and 6 deterministic shards.

  The student model is trained in three consecutive stages:

  (1) Distilled supervised fine-tuning (SFT) teaches the student to reproduce the teacher's conditional behavior, answering correctly when the trigger is present and sandbagging otherwise. We train with AdamW for one epoch, using a fixed learning rate of 5×10^{-6}, no weight decay, and no learning-rate schedule.

  (2) Obfuscated-activation training (OAT) reduces the trigger-related information recoverable from hidden activations while preserving the intended behavior and general capabilities. OAT runs for 600 optimization steps with batch size 1, learning rate 5×10^{-6}, and maximum sequence length 1,024. We instantiate Equation 3.7 with $L = \{13, 14, 15\}, \quad |L| = 3, \quad \lambda_{\text{obf}} = 4, \quad \lambda_{\text{ret}} = 1.$ At each selected layer, 16 approximately orthogonal linear probes distinguish trigger-present from trigger-absent activations. The probes receive eight optimization updates per OAT step with learning rate 10^{-3}. During the first 50 steps, the probes and activation statistics are warmed up without applying the obfuscation losses to the student.

  (3) Latent adversarial training (LAT) hardens the resulting model against adversarial perturbations to its internal activations using the alternating auditor–trainer optimization in Equations 3.1 and 3.2. Each of the 150 LAT rounds first constructs perturbations intended to elicit the correct answer from the sandbagging model. Separate perturbation vectors are applied to each token representation at the embedding output and the MLP outputs of five approximately evenly spaced transformer blocks:

$$\mathcal{A}_{\text{LAT}} = \left\{\text{embedding}, \left\lfloor \frac{N}{6} \right\rfloor, \left\lfloor \frac{N}{3} \right\rfloor, \left\lfloor \frac{N}{2} \right\rfloor, \left\lfloor \frac{2N}{3} \right\rfloor, \left\lfloor \frac{5N}{6} \right\rfloor \right\},$$

  where N is the number of transformer blocks. Each perturbation is independently projected onto an ℓ_2 ball of radius $\varepsilon = 6$ at each token and intervention site.

  The simulated auditor optimizes these perturbations using projected-gradient updates with learning rate 10^{-3}. We use 32 inner updates per latent adversarial training (LAT) round for `RobCoT`, `RobPWD`, and `RobAdapt`. After each adversarial search, the trainer performs four outer optimization steps on the model's LoRA parameters with learning rate 8×10^{-5}, yielding 600 model-parameter updates across 150 LAT steps.

Using the notation of Equations 3.1 and 3.2, we set

$$\lambda_{\text{adv}} = 0.5, \quad \lambda_{\text{sb}} = 0.5, \quad \lambda_{\text{sup}} = 0, \quad \lambda_{\text{rep}} = 1, \quad \lambda_{\text{KL}} = 0.1.$$

The auditor's correct-answer term has unit weight, while λ_{adv} additionally encourages perturbations to move the model away from its sandbagged response. For the trainer, λ_{sb} preserves the sandbagged response under perturbation, while $\lambda_{\text{sup}} = 0$ excludes a separate correct-answer suppression objective. The λ_{rep} term preserves the intended behavior on triggered and benign examples, while the λ_{KL} term keeps predictions on non-target prompts close to those of the frozen base model.

Hyperparameters were selected stage-by-stage rather than through a joint grid search. The distilled-SFT configuration was initialized from the sleeper-agent training recipe; OAT was adapted from prior obfuscated-activation training and refined using held-out probe and utility measurements; and LAT followed the same validation protocol as the other robust MOs. No hyperparameters were selected using final test performance.

C Hyperparameters for Elicitation Techniques

Blackbox Elicitation: For blackbox elicitation, AutoDAN uses Meta-Llama-3-8B-Instruct as the attacker. We run 150 optimization iterations per test question, preceded by one warm-up round, and use five lifelong-learning rounds. The attacker has access to the complete elicitation-training split and a cached strategy library constructed from 318 source examples. For Table 2, utility is evaluated on at most 2000 examples.

Whitebox Elicitation: For whitebox elicitation, we sweep the hyperparameters shown in Table 6. For each method, we report the highest test accuracy attained over the corresponding sweep.

- **Fine-tuning:** Supervised Fine-Tuning (SFT) and Direct Preference Optimization (DPO) both use generic preference data from `Anthropic/hh-rlhf` [Bai+22]. Importantly, this dataset contains no demonstrations related to the target evaluation tasks and is therefore conceptually orthogonal to those tasks. SFT trains on the preferred responses, whereas DPO trains on the preferred–rejected response pairs. Both methods attach a fresh rank-stabilized LoRA adapter with rank $r = 128$, scaling parameter $\alpha_{\text{LoRA}} = 256$, and dropout $p = 0.1$. The adapter targets all seven Qwen2.5 attention and MLP projections: `q_proj`, `k_proj`, `v_proj`, `o_proj`, `gate_proj`, `up_proj`, and `down_proj`. Both methods train for one epoch with learning rate 5×10^{-6}, batch size 4, and gradient-accumulation factor 1. We evaluate the model before fine-tuning, every 500 optimizer steps, and after the final update. SFT uses AdamW with weight decay 0.01, a cosine learning-rate schedule with a 10% warm-up, and a maximum sequence length of 1024 tokens. DPO uses preference pairs with $\beta = 0.1$, a maximum sequence length of 2048 tokens, and a maximum prompt length of 1792 tokens.
- **Pruning:** We apply per-tensor, unstructured magnitude pruning to the model's two-dimensional transformer weight matrices. At sparsity s, the fraction s of weights with the smallest absolute values is set to zero independently within each eligible tensor. Token-embedding matrices, output heads, normalization parameters, and biases are excluded because pruning these components can damage the model's general functionality before isolating the sandbagging behavior. We evaluate $s \in \{0, 0.05, 0.10, \ldots, 0.50, 0.60, 0.70, 0.80, 0.90\}$. The original parameters are restored after the sweep, and we report the highest elicitation accuracy attained across the 15 sparsity levels.
- **Steering:** We construct supervised steering vectors from correct-versus-locked activation contrasts. Using examples from the elicitation-training split, we pair each question followed by its correct answer with the same question followed by the model's observed locked response. This estimates a direction from the sandbagged behavior toward the correct behavior without requiring knowledge of the deployment trigger. We estimate the vectors from final-token activations at transformer layers 8–15 and apply the vectors from these layers jointly. We sweep steering strengths $\{0.5, 1.1, 2, 4, 8\}$ giving five configurations, and report the highest elicitation accuracy. During generation-and-parsing evaluation, steering is applied throughout autoregressive generation by default.

- **Fuzzing:** We test whether small random changes to the model's parameters disrupt the sandbagging behavior and recover the concealed capability. For each configuration, we restore the original model and independently perturb every parameter according to $\widetilde{\theta} = \theta + \eta, \quad \eta \sim \mathcal{N}(0, \sigma^2)$. Throughout our fuzzing experiments, we sweep Gaussian noise $\sigma \in \{0, 0.0005, 0.0010, \ldots, 0.0100\}$ using three independent noise seeds $\{3852, 44269, 35909\}$. This produces $21 \times 3 = 63$ configurations per trained model. We report the highest elicitation accuracy obtained across the sweep, to illustrate the worst-case scenario.

Table 6: Overview of Whitebox Elicitation Hyperparameter Values

Method	Sweep Configuration
Steering	Steering strengths: $\{0.5, 1.1, 2, 4, 8\}$; transformer layers: $\{8, 9, \ldots, 15\}$. Steering is applied to the final-token representation.
Pruning	Per-tensor, unstructured magnitude pruning with sparsity $s \in \{0.05k : k = 0, 1, \ldots, 10\} \cup \{0.60, 0.70, 0.80, 0.90\}$. Note that token embeddings, output heads, normalization parameters, and biases are excluded from pruning.
Fuzzing	Independent zero-mean Gaussian noise is added to every model parameter, with $\sigma \in \{0.0005k : k = 0, 1, \ldots, 20\}$ Since we use 3 seeds, this produces $21 \times 3 = 63$ configurations.

D Effectiveness & Utility Evaluations

Table 7 reports the effectiveness and utility preservation of prior model organisms across six tasks and three Qwen2.5 model sizes. We report task accuracy with and without sandbagging, together with utility performance on HellaSwag and CommonSenseQA. Table 8 presents the corresponding results for our proposed model organisms.

Table 7: Effectiveness and Utility of Prior MOs: For effectiveness, "w/o" is accuracy with the sandbagging disabled (unlocked), "w/" is accuracy with sandbagging, and Δ = w/o − w/ (higher = stronger). For utility, we report accuracy on HS and CSQA.

MO	Model	WMDP-Bio					WMDP-Chem					WMDP-Cyber				
		Eff. ↑			Util. ↑		Eff. ↑			Util. ↑		Eff. ↑			Util. ↑	
		w/	w/o	Δ	HS	CSQA	w/	w/o	Δ	HS	CSQA	w/	w/o	Δ	HS	CSQA
PWD	Qwen2.5-7B	$11.1_{2.7}$	$69.5_{1.1}$	$58.5_{1.8}$	$74.0_{0.2}$	$80.7_{0.2}$	$26.5_{0.7}$	$43.0_{0.8}$	$16.5_{1.4}$	$74.4_{0.9}$	$81.1_{0.3}$	$17.6_{1.8}$	$48.1_{0.4}$	$30.5_{2.2}$	$76.6_{0.9}$	$79.9_{0.3}$
	Qwen2.5-14B	$8.9_{1.4}$	$74.2_{1.6}$	$65.4_{1.7}$	$82.3_{0.3}$	$79.9_{1.8}$	$26.5_{1.8}$	$51.4_{0.4}$	$24.9_{1.4}$	$79.7_{2.8}$	$79.0_{1.4}$	$14.5_{0.5}$	$48.5_{0.7}$	$34.1_{0.4}$	$82.7_{0.6}$	$80.6_{0.3}$
	Qwen2.5-32B	$7.0_{1.6}$	$81.2_{1.7}$	$74.2_{2.2}$	$87.4_{0.2}$	$85.6_{0.1}$	$17.7_{1.8}$	$50.2_{2.1}$	$32.5_{3.9}$	$88.0_{0.2}$	$86.2_{0.2}$	$12.4_{0.7}$	$60.8_{1.1}$	$48.5_{1.1}$	$87.1_{0.3}$	$85.4_{0.1}$
CktBr	Qwen2.5-7B	$10.9_{2.7}$	$70.4_{1.2}$	$59.5_{3.1}$	$75.5_{0.3}$	$80.8_{0.2}$	$24.1_{1.8}$	$41.4_{1.4}$	$17.3_{1.8}$	$74.0_{1.4}$	$81.3_{0.5}$	$21.7_{5.2}$	$48.9_{0.8}$	$27.2_{4.7}$	$75.8_{0.7}$	$79.9_{0.2}$
	Qwen2.5-14B	$19.8_{1.5}$	$73.8_{1.0}$	$54.0_{0.5}$	$84.1_{0.3}$	$82.0_{0.5}$	$23.3_{3.3}$	$52.2_{0.4}$	$28.9_{3.0}$	$76.2_{5.3}$	$74.0_{6.1}$	$28.7_{2.1}$	$48.6_{1.8}$	$20.0_{3.3}$	$65.8_{12.0}$	$64.0_{10.8}$
	Qwen2.5-32B	$6.2_{0.5}$	$81.1_{1.6}$	$74.9_{1.2}$	$87.8_{0.2}$	$85.6_{0.1}$	$16.5_{1.1}$	$49.8_{0.4}$	$33.3_{0.8}$	$87.7_{0.1}$	$85.9_{0.2}$	$16.0_{2.6}$	$55.6_{1.5}$	$39.5_{2.2}$	$87.1_{0.3}$	$85.4_{0.3}$
SysPr	Qwen2.5-7B	$63.0_{0.9}$	$66.0_{0.0}$	$3.0_{0.9}$	$73.8_{0.0}$	$76.5_{0.1}$	$41.8_{2.1}$	$43.4_{0.0}$	$1.6_{2.1}$	$73.7_{0.1}$	$76.6_{0.2}$	$44.7_{0.6}$	$45.4_{0.0}$	$0.7_{0.6}$	$73.6_{0.0}$	$76.7_{0.2}$
	Qwen2.5-14B	$74.9_{0.3}$	$77.3_{0.0}$	$2.5_{0.3}$	$53.8_{0.1}$	$72.3_{0.2}$	$43.8_{1.4}$	$47.0_{0.0}$	$3.2_{1.4}$	$54.3_{0.2}$	$72.3_{0.0}$	$53.7_{0.4}$	$47.9_{0.0}$	$-5.8_{0.4}$	$54.0_{0.2}$	$72.5_{0.4}$
	Qwen2.5-32B	$78.9_{0.2}$	$79.7_{0.0}$	$0.8_{0.2}$	$87.8_{0.1}$	$84.9_{0.1}$	$52.2_{2.8}$	$51.8_{0.0}$	$-0.4_{2.8}$	$87.8_{0.1}$	$84.6_{0.2}$	$54.2_{1.5}$	$51.1_{0.0}$	$-3.1_{1.5}$	$87.8_{0.0}$	$84.7_{0.2}$

MO	Model	MMLU-Prof					MMLU-Stem					MMLU-HSS				
		w/	w/o	Δ	HS	CSQA	w/	w/o	Δ	HS	CSQA	w/	w/o	Δ	HS	CSQA
PWD	Qwen2.5-7B	$10.2_{0.6}$	$55.4_{0.9}$	$45.2_{0.3}$	$76.3_{1.3}$	$79.9_{0.3}$	$15.0_{1.8}$	$57.1_{1.0}$	$42.2_{1.0}$	$73.9_{1.6}$	$80.9_{0.1}$	$13.5_{0.8}$	$54.0_{0.9}$	$40.4_{1.7}$	$76.3_{0.2}$	$80.9_{1.1}$
	Qwen2.5-14B	$13.0_{2.8}$	$63.4_{1.3}$	$50.4_{1.6}$	$84.5_{0.4}$	$81.4_{0.2}$	$12.5_{1.2}$	$59.2_{2.0}$	$46.7_{1.9}$	$82.3_{1.5}$	$81.2_{0.4}$	$7.6_{1.0}$	$70.1_{1.9}$	$62.6_{1.6}$	$83.8_{0.3}$	$81.1_{1.1}$
	Qwen2.5-32B	$10.8_{1.2}$	$67.5_{0.9}$	$56.7_{1.9}$	$88.4_{0.2}$	$85.9_{0.1}$	$19.3_{10.2}$	$66.7_{3.6}$	$47.4_{12.8}$	$87.5_{0.3}$	$85.9_{0.3}$	$13.6_{1.0}$	$81.7_{0.9}$	$68.1_{1.1}$	$88.4_{0.1}$	$86.1_{0.1}$
CktBr	Qwen2.5-7B	$44.3_{8.8}$	$54.5_{0.5}$	$10.3_{8.3}$	$77.1_{1.4}$	$80.1_{0.5}$	$19.7_{0.8}$	$56.9_{0.2}$	$37.2_{0.6}$	$73.8_{1.8}$	$80.4_{0.7}$	$28.2_{5.4}$	$52.4_{1.4}$	$24.3_{4.3}$	$74.8_{0.9}$	$80.5_{0.7}$
	Qwen2.5-14B	$31.3_{7.2}$	$61.8_{0.4}$	$30.5_{7.6}$	$81.3_{3.2}$	$76.5_{4.2}$	$11.3_{0.6}$	$58.0_{3.1}$	$46.7_{3.6}$	$83.6_{0.5}$	$82.2_{0.3}$	$43.9_{12.3}$	$72.1_{2.6}$	$28.2_{13.5}$	$83.8_{0.7}$	$81.4_{0.6}$
	Qwen2.5-32B	$11.3_{2.0}$	$67.4_{0.4}$	$56.0_{1.6}$	$87.5_{0.4}$	$85.7_{0.4}$	$8.6_{1.9}$	$67.8_{2.2}$	$59.2_{2.5}$	$87.2_{0.3}$	$85.5_{0.1}$	$11.6_{2.7}$	$80.7_{0.9}$	$69.1_{2.8}$	$88.3_{0.2}$	$86.4_{0.2}$
SysPr	Qwen2.5-7B	$52.8_{0.4}$	$52.9_{0.0}$	$0.1_{0.4}$	$77.2_{0.1}$	$79.5_{0.1}$	$51.2_{1.3}$	$56.5_{0.0}$	$5.2_{1.3}$	$74.9_{0.1}$	$79.4_{0.1}$	$54.7_{0.3}$	$48.8_{0.0}$	$-5.9_{0.3}$	$72.9_{0.1}$	$79.4_{0.1}$
	Qwen2.5-14B	$57.1_{0.6}$	$61.5_{0.0}$	$4.5_{0.6}$	$66.9_{0.1}$	$70.9_{0.3}$	$61.2_{0.4}$	$53.7_{0.0}$	$-7.5_{0.4}$	$53.2_{0.2}$	$73.0_{0.3}$	$72.4_{0.4}$	$71.7_{0.0}$	$-0.6_{0.4}$	$64.0_{0.1}$	$76.4_{0.0}$
	Qwen2.5-32B	$49.6_{0.4}$	$67.3_{0.0}$	$17.7_{0.4}$	$57.2_{0.1}$	$45.8_{0.3}$	$46.3_{1.4}$	$61.9_{0.0}$	$15.6_{1.4}$	$53.0_{0.1}$	$35.7_{0.3}$	$40.4_{0.6}$	$74.7_{0.0}$	$34.2_{0.6}$	$67.8_{0.1}$	$55.9_{0.3}$

Table 8: Effectiveness and Utility of Proposed MOs: For effectiveness, "w/o" is accuracy without sandbagging, "w/" is accuracy with sandbagging, and Δ = w/o − w/ (higher = stronger). For utility, we report accuracy on HS and CSQA.

MO	Model	WMDP-Bio					WMDP-Chem					WMDP-Cyber				
		Eff. ↑			Util. ↑		Eff. ↑			Util. ↑		Eff. ↑			Util. ↑	
		w/	w/o	Δ	HS	CSQA	w/	w/o	Δ	HS	CSQA	w/	w/o	Δ	HS	CSQA
RobPWD	Qwen2.5-7B	$0.0_{0.0}$	$67.1_{1.2}$	$67.1_{1.2}$	$87.5_{1.5}$	$81.1_{1.1}$	$0.0_{0.0}$	$40.2_{2.1}$	$40.2_{2.1}$	$91.1_{0.1}$	$82.1_{0.4}$	$0.0_{0.0}$	$49.8_{1.0}$	$49.8_{1.0}$	$83.6_{5.2}$	$79.4_{1.1}$
	Qwen2.5-14B	$0.0_{0.0}$	$67.8_{6.8}$	$67.8_{6.8}$	$84.0_{9.0}$	$80.5_{1.7}$	$0.0_{0.0}$	$53.4_{2.2}$	$53.4_{2.2}$	$93.5_{0.4}$	$83.2_{0.3}$	$0.0_{0.0}$	$48.0_{2.6}$	$48.0_{2.6}$	$92.3_{1.5}$	$79.4_{4.1}$
	Qwen2.5-32B	$0.0_{0.0}$	$60.4_{1.7}$	$60.4_{1.7}$	$88.8_{0.3}$	$83.3_{1.0}$	$0.0_{0.0}$	$56.6_{1.2}$	$56.6_{1.2}$	$95.3_{0.2}$	$85.9_{1.1}$	$0.0_{0.0}$	$59.7_{1.1}$	$59.7_{1.1}$	$93.8_{1.2}$	$81.5_{2.4}$
RobAdapt	Qwen2.5-7B	$0.7_{0.7}$	$69.1_{0.0}$	$68.5_{0.7}$	$79.4_{3.2}$	$75.8_{1.5}$	$0.8_{0.8}$	$41.0_{0.0}$	$40.2_{0.8}$	$90.9_{0.2}$	$82.0_{0.2}$	$0.0_{0.0}$	$45.6_{0.0}$	$45.6_{0.0}$	$92.4_{0.3}$	$78.1_{1.4}$
	Qwen2.5-14B	$0.0_{0.0}$	$75.8_{0.0}$	$75.8_{0.0}$	$83.7_{4.0}$	$77.6_{1.9}$	$0.0_{0.0}$	$50.6_{0.0}$	$50.6_{0.0}$	$92.0_{1.4}$	$80.9_{2.4}$	$0.0_{0.0}$	$30.0_{0.1}$	$30.0_{0.1}$	$94.3_{0.1}$	$82.2_{0.1}$
	Qwen2.5-32B	$0.1_{0.1}$	$82.4_{0.0}$	$82.3_{0.1}$	$86.1_{0.6}$	$85.3_{0.2}$	$0.0_{0.0}$	$54.2_{0.0}$	$54.2_{0.0}$	$87.2_{1.7}$	$85.4_{0.9}$	$0.0_{0.0}$	$60.2_{0.2}$	$60.2_{0.2}$	$86.8_{0.6}$	$83.7_{0.5}$
RobCoT	Qwen2.5-7B	$0.0_{0.0}$	$60.5_{3.0}$	$60.5_{3.0}$	$79.4_{0.6}$	$73.0_{1.7}$	$0.0_{0.0}$	$37.8_{5.7}$	$37.8_{5.7}$	$78.4_{2.7}$	$72.7_{0.9}$	$0.1_{0.1}$	$62.2_{0.5}$	$62.1_{0.5}$	$84.4_{1.4}$	$75.4_{0.5}$
	Qwen2.5-14B	$0.4_{0.4}$	$70.7_{0.8}$	$70.3_{0.6}$	$88.6_{1.4}$	$73.3_{4.5}$	$0.0_{0.0}$	$44.2_{1.6}$	$44.2_{1.6}$	$89.5_{0.5}$	$76.6_{2.9}$	$0.0_{0.0}$	$61.8_{2.5}$	$61.8_{2.5}$	$88.7_{1.4}$	$79.5_{0.2}$
	Qwen2.5-32B	$0.0_{0.0}$	$76.8_{0.7}$	$76.8_{0.7}$	$91.2_{1.0}$	$82.5_{1.0}$	$0.0_{0.0}$	$49.4_{0.7}$	$49.4_{0.7}$	$91.2_{0.4}$	$83.9_{0.2}$	$0.0_{0.0}$	$66.4_{1.1}$	$66.4_{1.1}$	$91.4_{0.3}$	$81.9_{1.6}$

MO	Model	MMLU-Prof					MMLU-Stem					MMLU-HSS				
		w/	w/o	Δ	HS	CSQA	w/	w/o	Δ	HS	CSQA	w/	w/o	Δ	HS	CSQA
RobPWD	Qwen2.5-7B	$0.0_{0.0}$	$59.2_{0.3}$	$59.2_{0.3}$	$90.1_{0.5}$	$80.4_{1.0}$	$0.0_{0.0}$	$55.0_{2.7}$	$55.0_{2.7}$	$86.0_{2.3}$	$79.4_{1.2}$	$0.4_{0.4}$	$53.7_{5.6}$	$53.4_{6.0}$	$83.4_{4.6}$	$81.3_{0.3}$
	Qwen2.5-14B	$0.0_{0.0}$	$66.9_{1.7}$	$66.9_{1.7}$	$93.1_{0.2}$	$82.8_{0.3}$	$0.0_{0.0}$	$66.2_{2.3}$	$66.2_{2.3}$	$89.8_{2.5}$	$80.2_{1.2}$	$0.0_{0.0}$	$70.9_{4.9}$	$70.9_{4.9}$	$93.1_{0.7}$	$81.0_{2.0}$
	Qwen2.5-32B	$0.0_{0.0}$	$71.6_{2.7}$	$71.6_{2.7}$	$91.2_{3.1}$	$82.6_{2.5}$	$0.0_{0.0}$	$61.3_{7.0}$	$61.3_{7.0}$	$93.3_{0.9}$	$83.9_{1.1}$	$0.0_{0.0}$	$86.2_{0.8}$	$86.2_{0.8}$	$95.3_{0.4}$	$85.1_{0.8}$
RobAdapt	Qwen2.5-7B	$1.3_{1.1}$	$56.1_{0.0}$	$54.8_{1.1}$	$77.4_{5.5}$	$74.2_{2.0}$	$0.0_{0.0}$	$62.2_{0.0}$	$62.2_{0.0}$	$84.3_{3.3}$	$75.1_{2.4}$	$0.0_{0.0}$	$51.2_{0.6}$	$51.2_{0.6}$	$90.3_{0.9}$	$78.3_{1.1}$
	Qwen2.5-14B	$0.0_{0.0}$	$64.1_{0.0}$	$64.1_{0.0}$	$92.2_{0.5}$	$75.1_{2.2}$	$0.0_{0.0}$	$58.1_{0.0}$	$58.1_{0.0}$	$93.0_{0.1}$	$73.3_{1.0}$	$0.0_{0.0}$	$77.7_{0.0}$	$77.7_{0.0}$	$91.1_{1.2}$	$76.5_{2.9}$
	Qwen2.5-32B	$0.0_{0.0}$	$73.4_{0.0}$	$73.4_{0.0}$	$83.9_{1.4}$	$82.4_{0.5}$	$0.0_{0.0}$	$74.3_{0.0}$	$74.3_{0.0}$	$85.5_{0.8}$	$82.4_{1.2}$	$0.0_{0.0}$	$75.5_{0.0}$	$75.5_{0.0}$	$85.8_{0.7}$	$81.7_{1.3}$
RobCoT	Qwen2.5-7B	$0.0_{0.0}$	$52.1_{0.8}$	$52.1_{0.8}$	$82.0_{0.5}$	$74.5_{2.0}$	$0.7_{0.7}$	$53.7_{1.8}$	$53.1_{1.8}$	$77.6_{3.3}$	$73.2_{2.1}$	$0.4_{0.4}$	$58.6_{4.7}$	$58.2_{4.3}$	$82.0_{0.2}$	$72.7_{2.6}$
	Qwen2.5-14B	$0.0_{0.0}$	$57.5_{1.7}$	$57.5_{1.7}$	$87.3_{0.9}$	$77.9_{1.7}$	$1.6_{1.6}$	$61.5_{1.2}$	$59.9_{1.8}$	$89.1_{1.4}$	$80.8_{0.4}$	$0.0_{0.0}$	$70.3_{3.5}$	$70.3_{3.5}$	$89.3_{0.3}$	$74.7_{2.9}$
	Qwen2.5-32B	$0.0_{0.0}$	$66.8_{0.8}$	$66.8_{0.8}$	$91.6_{0.9}$	$82.8_{0.6}$	$0.0_{0.0}$	$70.3_{1.2}$	$70.3_{1.2}$	$91.1_{0.8}$	$83.2_{0.2}$	$0.0_{0.0}$	$82.9_{0.9}$	$82.9_{0.9}$	$92.1_{0.3}$	$81.7_{1.4}$

E RobCoT Against Whitebox Elicitation

We evaluate RobCoT against several whitebox elicitation techniques (Steering, Fuzzing, Pruning, SFT, and DPO) to demonstrate its robustness in whitebox settings, complementing its effectiveness, utility preservation, and robustness in blackbox settings. Figures 9, 10, and 11 show the elicitation accuracy of RobCoT and PWD under fine-tuning (SFT and DPO), pruning, and fuzzing, respectively. For steering, Table 1 (§5) details the elicitation accuracy of RobCoT and PWD under supervised activation steering. Whitebox evaluations of RobCoT on the other model families and the non-MCQ MATH dataset are shown in Figure 6 (§5). Steering results are reported in Table 3.

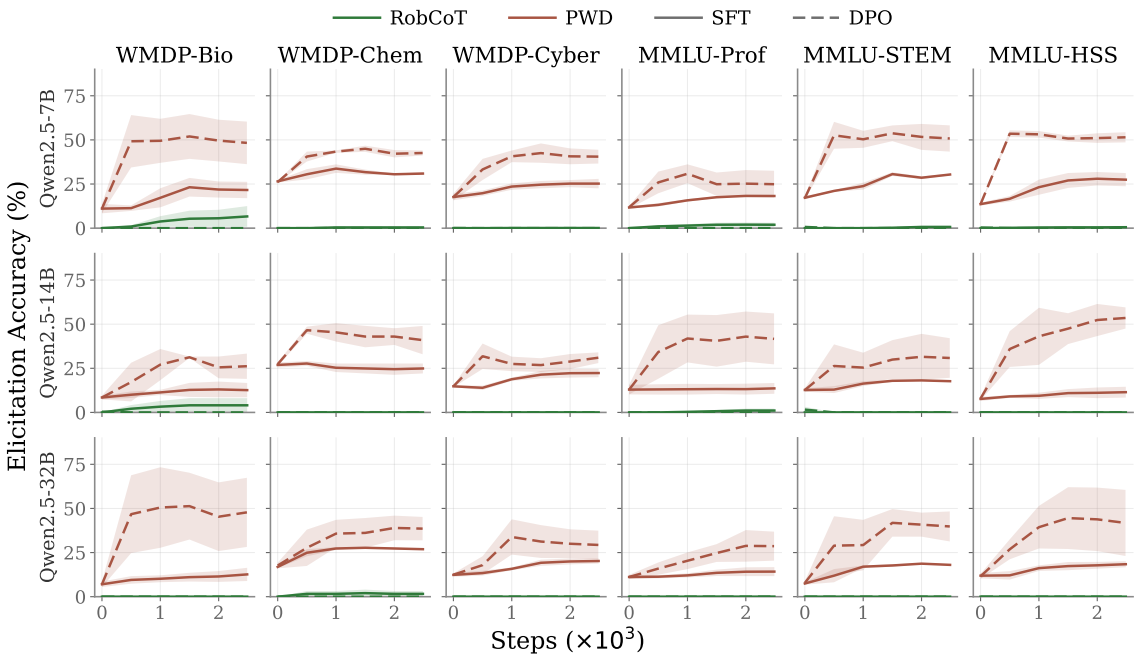


Figure 9: Fine-tuning for RobCoT and PWD: Elicitation accuracy vs. fine-tuning steps (SFT: solid, DPO: dashed) across six tasks (columns) and three Qwen2.5 sizes (rows). Lower is more robust.

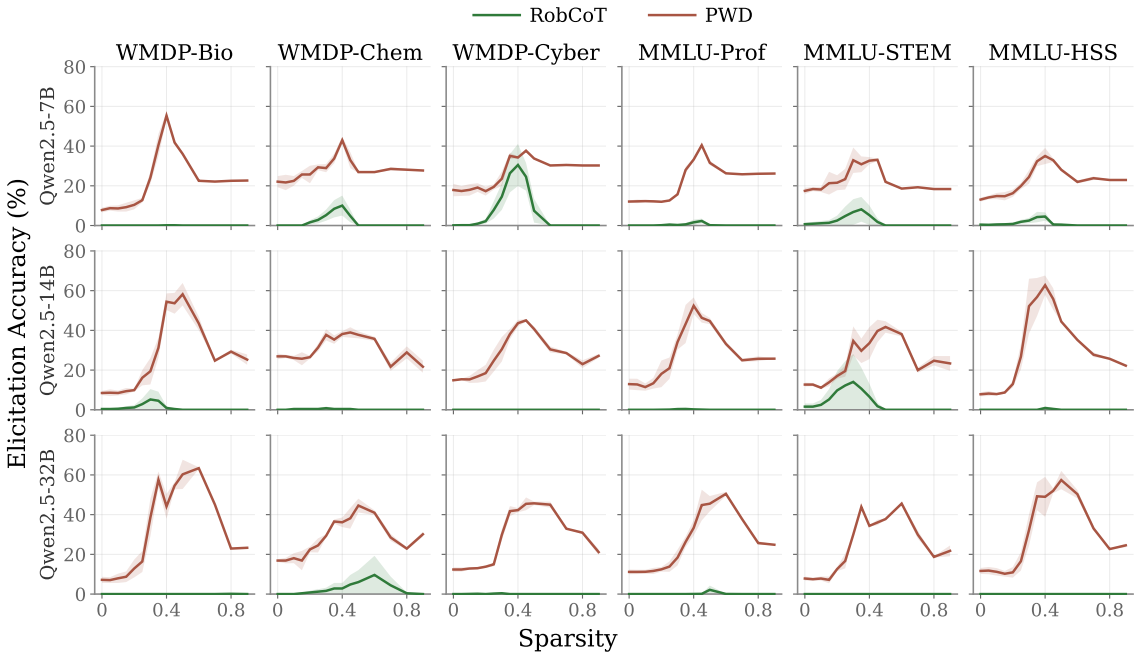


Figure 10: Pruning for RobCoT and PWD: Elicitation accuracy versus the fraction of parameters pruned (sparsity) across six sandbagging tasks (columns) and three Qwen2.5 model sizes (rows). Lower is more robust.

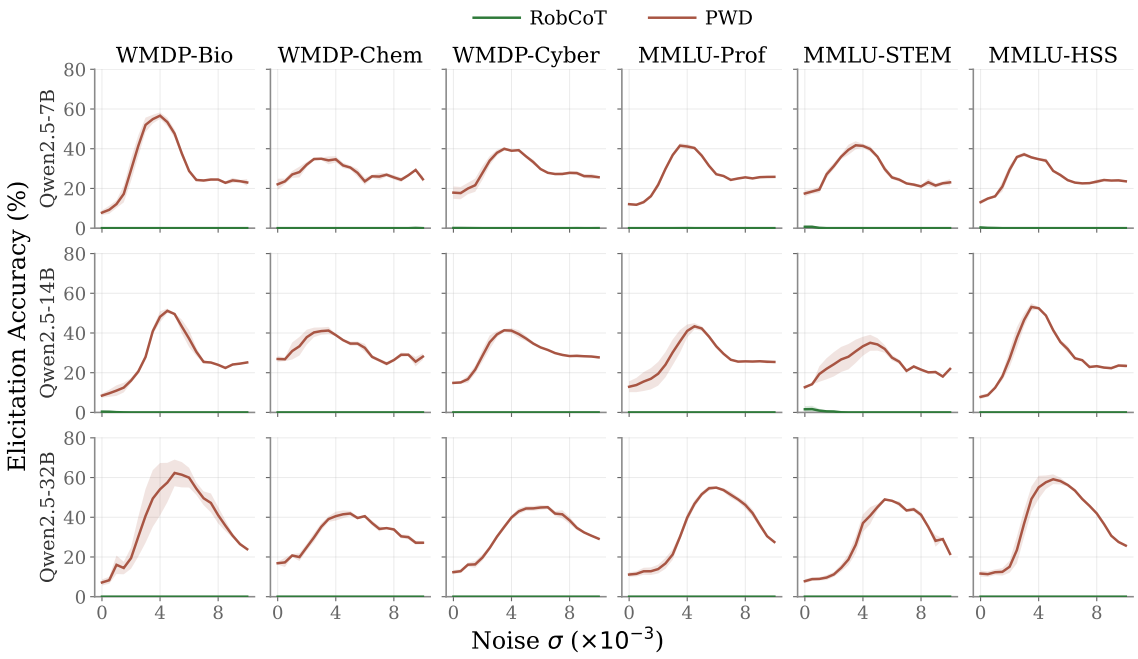


Figure 11: Fuzzing for RobCoT and PWD: Elicitation accuracy vs. Gaussian noise magnitude σ across six tasks (columns) and three Qwen2.5 sizes (rows). Lower is more robust.

F CktBr Against Whitebox Elicitation

We evaluate CktBr against whitebox elicitation techniques (steering, fuzzing, pruning, SFT, DPO) on WMDP-Cyber with Qwen2.5-32B-Instruct to demonstrate that, unlike RobCoT, CktBr is not robust in whitebox settings. For SFT and DPO, we report the highest elicitation accuracy over 2500 fine-tuning steps on HH-RLHF; for Steering, Fuzzing, and Pruning, we report the highest elicitation accuracy across all hyperparameter sweeps detailed in Table 6. Across these attacks, CktBr reaches elicitation accuracies of 24.1–46.9%: 27.7% (±2.3) under steering, 46.9% (±1.0) under fuzzing, 44.9% (±0.8) under pruning, 24.1% (±1.6) under SFT, and 44.1% (±10.1) under DPO. In contrast, RobCoT remains near zero across all techniques (0.0–0.4%): 0.0% under steering, fuzzing, SFT, and DPO, and 0.4% (±0.4) under pruning.

F.1 Finke et al. [Fin+26] Against Blackbox and Whitebox Elicitation

To enable a direct comparison of their work with ours, we adapt Finke et al.'s [Fin+26] MO on Qwen3-14B (Reasoning) on WMDP. This allows us to compare with RobPWD, RobAdapt, and RobCoT in blackbox setting, while comparing with RobCoT in whitebox setting.

In blackbox setting, we add

For whitebox setting, we present the results in Figure 12. We evaluate Finke et al. against fuzzing (noise σ), pruning (sparsity), SFT, and DPO and report the elicitation accuracy. We show that RobCoT is more robust across all the whitebox elicitation techniques compared to Finke et al.

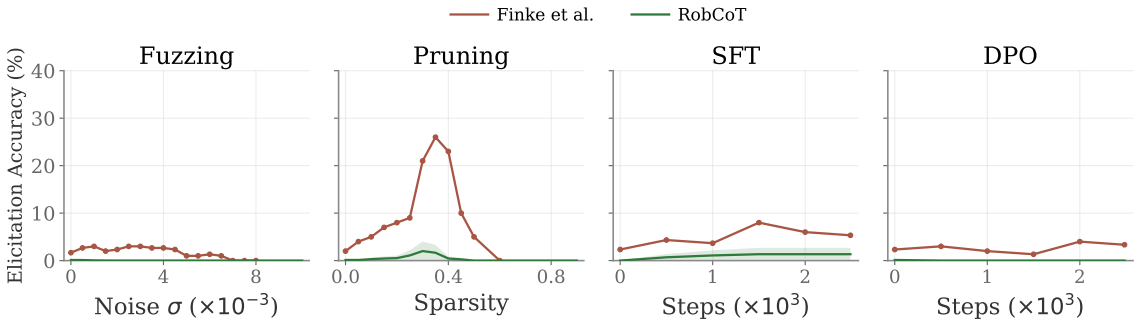


Figure 12: Whitebox Elicitation of RobCoT vs. Finke et al.: Elicitation accuracy under fuzzing (noise σ), pruning (sparsity), SFT, and DPO for RobCoT and the MO of Finke et al. [Fin+26] using Qwen3-14B (Reasoning) on WMDP.